MEDIATOR GUIDE TO RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Relationships Matter to Mediators

People with the Mediator personality type are Introverts, which means that they need alone time to recharge their energy, but they still crave meaningful connections with others. Beneath their reserved exteriors, Mediators are deeply sensitive and caring, brimming with love and goodwill that they long to share. For Mediators, having close relationships with friends and loved ones is a key part of what makes life worthwhile.

It's no surprise, then, that relationships – with their romantic partners, their friends, and their family members – mean a great deal to Mediators. Mediators dedicate themselves to developing an in-depth understanding of the people in their lives, and they use this understanding to promote harmony, show empathy, and gently elevate the people they care about in beautiful, subtle ways.

Deeply compassionate, people with this personality type open themselves fully to those they love and give of their energies freely. Mediators are a sincere well of support and love, minimally judgmental, and very open-minded. They take pride in their ability to attune themselves to other people's needs and to be there for those who matter to them.

The Challenges of Mediator Relationships

At times, Mediators' emotionally giving nature can leave these types feeling neglected themselves. Not everyone can understand Mediators in the way that Mediators understand others. Moreover, Mediators can be reluctant to bring up their own issues and ask loved ones for help, attention, or support. People with this personality type think nothing of extending their hearts to others, yet many times, they don't feel comfortable asking for the same care that they so readily give.

Mediators' sensitivity is among their greatest assets, but it can also pose challenges in their relationships. They may feel slights that others don't intend – for example, they might assume that a friend or loved one who is too busy to meet up doesn't want to see them. This can lead to misunderstandings and leave Mediators feeling quite vulnerable.

Fortunately, Mediators are more than capable of drawing on their gifts – including compassion, thoughtfulness, and faith in human nature – to cultivate the meaningful, sustaining relationships that they crave. In this guide, we'll discuss how Mediators tend to show up in their romantic relationships, their friendships, and – if they become parents – their family life. Along the way, Mediators will learn how to lean into their strengths, foster open communication, and acknowledge their own needs in the same way that they so generously acknowledge the needs of the people who matter to them.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Romantic Relationships

Seeking a Deep Connection

Mediators are starry-eyed, romantic idealists who often daydream about perfect relationships abundant in harmony and warmth – a union of souls communicating their deepest truths and feelings. For these types, looking for partners or nurturing existing relationships are often essential goals. This idealism is among their most appealing romantic qualities, even if it sometimes sets them up for disappointment when others can't match their pure, open-hearted love.

These types offer their partners bright enthusiasm and joy, using their vivid imaginations to come up with insightful ways to keep their romantic relationships lively. This is a particularly endearing quality in early dating – the fun never stops with Mediators. Many of the other personality types thrill at the novelty that Mediators bring to dates, while others struggle to keep up with brilliance, whimsy, and spontaneity, especially amidst the uncertainty and unfamiliarity of early dating.

Mediators engage deeply with ideas, beliefs, and dreams, which can challenge partners of personality types that think mainly in routine and live by a plan. When partners don't share their fondness for the fantastical, abstract dimensions of things, Mediators may lose interest – they want lovers to at least listen to their imaginings. Moreover, these types want to share in their partners' dreams and to participate with gentle encouragement and excitement. It's only natural that they want their partners to reciprocate.

Embracing Change

Mediators possess a quiet lightness of being and can be very optimistic and accepting even in the face of unforeseen events. They appreciate moving into new experiences. However, their energy can swing like a pendulum. They may be warmly social with close friends and lovers sometimes and contemplative and solitary at other times – with these same people. These types embrace the transitions, and those who love them face a lot of unexpected changes.

Mediators' views on romantic relationships may often be poetic, but they're not always realistic. Their tendency to idealize their lovers can sometimes create confusion as both partners react to changing expectations. However, if Mediators are mature enough to recognize and address these tendencies, they reap great rewards in their efforts toward personal growth. Even if their imaginations get carried away now and then, Mediators treat their romantic partners to deep, caring warmth that transcends many problems.

A Need for Harmony

While they adapt wonderfully to many aspects of love, Mediators' desire for harmony with their partners means that they typically avoid criticism and conflict. While this can contribute to the stability of their relationships, it can also cause subtle problems. These types may find it hard to speak up for their own interests, often allowing their needs to become secondary to those of their lovers. This lack of communication has the potential to disrupt the balance in a relationship, and it can be a hard habit to break.

Even when they make their voices heard, Mediators may struggle to receive criticism or hear contradictory ideas without interpreting them as faults in themselves – they're highly sensitive and may respond with anger or simply feel wounded. They almost reflexively sublimate themselves in favor of those they love, and while this is wonderful with romantic partners who are equally caring and perceptive, it's not always fair with those less sensitive than they are.

Adapting to Love

While the potential exists for these types to lose touch with their own needs amidst their devotion to their partners, they also find great joy

in adapting to other people's unique presence in their lives. Love gives Mediators a chance to experience new perspectives, and a balanced version of "losing themselves" in their partners can be magical, as if they enter another world by engaging with their partners' desires. When they maintain their own perceptions and preferences as well, such discovery together can be exciting and healthy.

Another wonderful facet of Mediators' ability to explore and adapt is that they open the minds of stubborn or tradition-bound partners. Highly empathetic, people with this personality type aren't likely to judge their loved ones. However, through gentle coaxing, they can easily make people think twice about their habits, opening them to new ideas. Mediators' imaginative curiosity can be inspiring, and partners immersed in their own daily routine can find their sweet influence as freeing as a vacation.

Potential Role Pairings

Unique Opportunities

Every personality type brings different things to their romantic relationships, and knowing a little about what to expect from different Role groups helps Mediators get to know potential partners and build solid relationships. However, it's important to remember that people are unique, regardless of their type, and while a perfect romance can exist in novels and television shows, the real world is not so perfect. Any people who fall in love may get along wonderfully and may have a few problems. In healthy relationships, they're likely to experience both.

In this section, we lay out guidance on how Mediators and other types can better understand each other, including some of the more likely areas of conflict between them. Warm, empathetic, and adaptable, Mediators can truly find balanced love with any other type, so long as the individuals involved demonstrate qualities that enable fair and loving connections.

Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Love between Mediators and Analysts often grows from the way that they balance each other's weaknesses and learn from each other's strengths. Linked by the Intuitive trait, both types can see the wonderful possibilities that the other brings into their lives, and both find such potential intriguing. Mediators think in terms of human connection and Analysts in terms of rational processes, and, in each other, these imaginative lovers find not only a whole new way of thinking but also new dimensions of themselves.

Balanced Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Shared Imagination

Mediators' imagination can provide great ways to get to know Analyst partners. Both thrive on creative discussions, from sharing ideas about a product they're developing to explaining the intricacies of a book they're writing. Analyst partners find it easy to keep up with imaginative processes and delight in assisting with brainstorming on any front. Complex and abstract ideas enthrall these pairs, and they can spend endless hours together discussing philosophical topics or coming up with ideas.

Relationships between Mediators and Analysts can be incredibly rewarding, as these individuals look at things from a different yet somehow familiar perspective. When Mediators are interested in complex topics, they spend a significant amount of time not just studying the concrete details but also contemplating the intangible side of the topic. Analysts are often impressed by the depth of understanding that Mediators gain by using their hearts as well as their minds.

Mediators are no less impressed by Analysts' ability to make decisions through rational processes. Those who maintain open-mindedness see the value in Analysts' ability to remain objective, a detachment that Mediators sometimes find personally challenging. They appreciate Analyst partners who anchor their fantastical take on life with blunt intellectualism. In turn, their Analyst lovers value Mediators' ability to take any imagined subject to the next level.

Discovering New Abilities

Besides sharing complementary imaginations, these couples can be profoundly helpful to each other's growth. They can learn a lot from each other in how they express emotion differently. Analysts have plenty of emotion but rarely place emphasis on expressing or understanding their feelings and may even deride such efforts, often seeming distant and clumsy with such matters. Mediators are perfectly suited to helping Analysts understand this side of themselves, providing an example of being in touch with their feelings.

This learning goes the other way as well. To be frank, Mediators are a type likely to become lost in emotion, especially during upsetting events. There are many moments in life where they'd be wise to step back, detach, and think about what's happening instead of being swept along by their feelings. The cool-headed example of thoughtful Analyst partners helps them practice such skills during moments of heightened emotion. Having them by their side as an example is a powerful reminder to Mediators of the self-control that they can develop if they choose.

The balance these two can bring each other translates directly into daily life, not just abstract concepts of growth. Mediators are pulled to share wondrous personal expressions of creativity with the world, but the logistics of how to successfully do so may be hard for them to master. Analyst partners can help them fit all the little logical pieces together to reach those goals. Likewise, Analysts are likely to struggle with friction in the social world, as they often lack tact and sensitivity. When they bring their social problems to Mediator partners, they receive invaluable human insights that enable them to improve their relationships.

Unbalanced Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Silent Damage

Romantic gestures typically send messages of interest, but the differences in how these two types express themselves can lead to hurt feelings or missed connections. Unaccustomed as they usually are to an emotional approach, Analysts may not understand the importance of sweet little romantic steps, or they may perform them with forced sincerity as they try and match expectations. Mediators – who read much depth into even minor actions – are easily disappointed by such half-hearted efforts, so even gestures that represent sincere interest may seem shallow to them. Initial connections can be tough when these two types don't take a balanced, understanding approach to each other's different ways of expressing romance.

Analysts invest a lot of effort in deciding their priorities, but intimate emotional relations are rarely high on their list unless they're made aware of a need. Even the most caring Analysts are unlikely to proffer the kind of lush, emotional interaction that their Mediator lovers crave. Instead, they prioritize what they see as functional contributions to their romantic relationships. Their practical efforts may not satisfy Mediators' need for intimate connection, however, and real problems can occur when Mediators remain silent about what they really want. Analysts can certainly learn to meet their partners' needs but rarely do so without prompting and steady guidance. Without it, this deficit can grow intolerable until Mediators explode with emotion – simply confusing Analysts further.

Out of Sync Priorities

These two types might learn to balance their expressions of emotion, but when Mediators and Analysts don't respect each other's priorities, ongoing and increasing friction can result. There's no specific subject where these two always differ – different criteria for decision-making and different preferences on where they want to put their energy mean that these two can find a lot to disagree about. It's likely that neither type is wrong, but this may still become a problem when they don't fairly balance their right to their own pursuits with their responsibility to mutual needs and concern for each other's goals.

Mediators often model their priorities in life around exploring the intangible, including emotional connections, and they love to share this exploration with their partners. They may not understand why Analysts don't share their values, however, and can easily become hurt and resentful. Analysts focus on systems, tactics, and rational processes. When they take this perspective too far, they may dismiss Mediators' lofty ideas and consequently miss opportunities to expand their imaginations.

In romantic relationships, some level of mutual effort toward the common good is needed. When these types disagree on how to proceed, however, it's hard to get anything done. Over time, they may lose their sense of balance, leading them to resent each other for the time, energy, and money that they spend on "unimportant" things. If they don't find ways to address life's everyday responsibilities together, everything from debt to dirty laundry can start to pile up in their lives.

Rebalancing Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Improving Communication

Working to understand their emotional differences can smooth over potential conflicts for Mediator-Analyst couples, especially early in their relationships. There's little in the way of an adequate substitute for understanding, which takes time and effort. However, when these partners are respectful and encouraging, this process brings them closer together. Mediators can help their Analyst lovers to reveal more of their feelings by setting a positive example of openness, asking them to share, and being encouraging when they do. Though Analysts may express some cynical thoughts, discussing feelings together is a huge step toward balance for these couples. Mediators can also avoid asking for too much, too fast – Analysts have a right to privacy in their own heads, just like anyone else.

An important step for both types is listening – simply taking in what their partners are saying without immediate comment. Since Analysts are unlikely to naturally respond with empathy, this deliberate reflection allows them to develop appropriate responses that support their partners' needs and feelings. In turn, Mediators can use such

contemplation to moderate the emotion in their responses. When these couples practice being emotionally perceptive, they achieve a more complete form of intelligence that enhances their relationships. These partners can use the following to help them navigate this area of personal growth together:

- Schedule more in-depth "sharing time" at the end of each week.
    - Planning this sharing around an unrelated but pleasant activity can make an uncomfortable talk easier. Consider a fancier than normal dinner, shared bath, or a walk outside – something each person enjoys.
- Use this time to talk about the highlights of each other's week, including emotional difficulties and personal triumphs.
- Ask about each other's thoughts and feelings daily, sharing honestly but doing so *simply* – avoid overloading each other with words and ask for emotional support whenever needed.
- Validate each other's feelings with the occasional show of approval.
- Focus on creating an aura of relaxation and interest.
- Hold back complaints about each other for another time. Keep this time as a free space where partners are comfortable and respected.

In balanced relationships, verbal affirmations of understanding and appreciation are needed from both types of partners. Mediators can take the lead by demonstrating and encouraging nonjudgmental, emotional openness with their Analyst lovers. Even if one partner chooses not to share everything all the time, they'll love knowing that the other is always ready to listen with love.

Accepting Each Other's Priorities

Mediators and Analysts don't need to fully understand or agree with each other's priorities in life, but in balanced relationships, they do respect and actively support those distinct pursuits. However, for their lives together to be functional and enjoyable, they must also agree on certain realities that affect them daily, such as household chores, shared bills, and social or work obligations. It's important that these

couples handle these sorts of priorities before they pour their hearts into more personal pursuits. Otherwise, they may find their freedom threatened by unfinished, mounting responsibilities. Cooperation can make quick work of such things: they just need to sit down, plan, and then act – together.

When Mediator-Analyst couples see their mutual priorities accomplished, they find it a lot easier to support each other's personal pursuits. It's also a wonderful demonstration of love to participate in things that are important to their significant other, if they want the company. Directly experiencing each other's personal passions goes a long way toward rebalancing differences, and each may find it unexpectedly interesting.

If Analysts are obsessed with some technology, they're likely thrilled at the chance to explain it to Mediators who, in turn, may appreciate seeing its inner workings more clearly, tapping into their natural curiosity. Likewise, Mediators may have personal hobbies to share that Analysts may find interesting, from art, literature, and music to their favorite games. Neither type should feel obligated or pressured to spend their personal time on the other's interests, but they can benefit greatly by at least trying them out by:

- Discussing daily and weekly priorities with each other.
- Identifying and agreeing on matters that are of mutual benefit and sharing the work.
- Making things interesting by trying out different, new ideas to see what works best.
- Ensuring that each partner is free to jump in if they have an inspiration on how to get it done best.
- Completing routine matters before moving on to individual pursuits.
- Inviting each other into personal pursuits and positively demonstrating their appeal in front of each other.
- Devoting some time and energy to supporting each other's personal projects and goals, especially if they focus on development and accomplishment.

The core appreciation that Mediators and Analysts feel for each other as individuals can be a source of motivation to balance their perspectives. Analysts may not care about painting, and Mediators might find engines boring, but if that's their partners' taste, they can cheerfully support them.

Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Mediators find a good sense of connection with fellow Diplomats, often growing close with them quickly – which isn't always easy for these sensitive types. While they have some notable differences within their Role group, Mediators and other Diplomats together as romantic couples have core commonalities that form the basis of both wonderful strengths and a few weaknesses. If they have a fault, it can be caring too much and the attendant emotional drama that this may sometimes bring. But, because they connect so well at the heart, Mediators and Diplomats in love have an unsurpassed capacity to sustain each other for a lifetime.

Balanced Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Emotional Resonance

Thanks to their similar emotional filters for viewing life, harmony develops organically between these types, with partners expressing their thoughts and feelings in open and empathetic ways. While this dynamic doesn't always contribute to objective thought, these lovers do become deeply attuned to each other's desires and needs and are usually quite enthusiastic about making each other happy. When such

people feel each other's emotions so strongly, it's only natural that they want to share as much joy together as possible.

In relationships with Diplomats, Mediators may feel that someone finally understands them – their strong emotional connection acts as a foundation to enable other forms of communication. These partners can share ideas, opinions, and problems together, counting on this underlying bond to help them navigate their differences and difficulties. Sensitive, emotional people may indeed be prone to some fiery fights, but when real love is present, they can make it up to each other and be stronger for it. Despite perfectly normal rocky spots now and then, Mediator-Diplomat couples who invest in long-term relationships find that they become essential parts of each other's happiness.

A Pair of Dreamers

The resonant bonds these couples form can support more than just their happiness when they're together – it also strengthens them as individuals following their own paths. People of similar (or even identical) personality types might have different interests, passions, and life goals, but something Mediators and Diplomats do share are highly active imaginations. These two find their collaborative ideas marvelous, and while they might not share equal interest in everything, they become fans and supporters of each other's dreams.

This is a personality type that often struggles to act, even when they're inspired, so having a supportive partner is an excellent way for Mediators to realize their own goals. Sometimes the push they need to move themselves forward comes from a Diplomat partner contributing their happy energy. These types might even end up sharing some goals as a couple, and when they complement their dreaming with a dose of effort, they become partners in achievement as well as love. Whether it's saving up to go on a trip, founding a charity, or redesigning an apartment, these couples can achieve anything when they cooperate.

Unbalanced Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Emotional Burnout

As wonderful as strong, bonded emotions can be, maintaining such a

deep connection and constantly catering to each other's feelings can exhaust even the most emotionally attuned types. Mediator-Diplomat couples who become too interdependent may not only lose their individual emotional stability – they may stifle each other. Passionate desire for each other's attention, reassurance, and company becomes unbalanced when it approaches addictive need – it's risky on its own and potentially overwhelming for overburdened partners with their own needs. When these wonderfully interconnected partners take their emotional exchanges too far, they can become codependent in all the wrong ways.

One of the biggest problems with this codependence is that it assumes too much. Everyone has limits. When Mediators or Diplomats take their adoration too far and idealistically view their partners as their primary sources for emotional validation, even minor flaws or missteps on the part of their lovers may seem shockingly disappointing. Idolization of each other may be hard to avoid, especially when new love is forming with truly remarkable individuals, but if it isn't balanced with a little realism, it can set up an overreaction. Mediators and Diplomats tend to be vulnerable to having their high hopes dashed by reality, but when the source of their disappointments are the people they love, the damage can be unpleasant. Blame is often the result when codependent relationships begin to show their inevitable weaknesses.

Lofty Distractions

Mediator-Diplomat couples have a troubling tendency to distract each other from everyday realities. They often get lost in their shared world of ideas and possibilities, drifting from one grand concept to another while ignoring immediate concerns. While this can produce wonderful creativity and insight, it might not result in a stable life. Without taking the time to enjoy the present and focus on simple realities, practical sensibility can be lacking in these relationships. Setting unrealistic goals isn't always conducive to success, but these two types might never notice because they're so enthusiastically chasing potentials together. These couples can suffer very unpleasant consequences when distraction leads to neglect of practical matters.

Mediator-Diplomat romantic relationships risk more than just daily upkeep, however. They can develop grandiose plans that continually

drain their resources, never quite work out how they want, and eclipse much-needed pragmatic planning. While mere striving may be satisfying, at some point these couples can feel a lack of realism in very basic ways. Lives spent painting or fighting injustice may have tremendous spiritual payoffs, but even the most idealistic couples need a roof over their heads and enough money to take care of themselves in retirement – and time to slow down and just enjoy life.

Rebalancing Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Individual Emotional Strength

Before seeking emotional fulfillment in each other, these partners can work to develop their independence. One excellent way to do this is for Mediator-Diplomat couples to do fun things apart from each other as well as together. Whether indulging in solitude or time spent with friends and family, these partners become better sources of strength for each other when they're strong on their own. Stepping back now and then doesn't in any way diminish their powerful connection, but it can ensure that they stay in touch with themselves. Space is essential for authentic, personal thoughts and feelings to be affirmed without anyone else's energy in the mix, and to rebalance their relationships, loving partners can respect the need for this space.

This approach can also help rebalance one of the most unpleasant aspects of emotional interdependence between Mediators and Diplomats: the tendency to reflect each other's negative emotional states. When feelings like joy or physical arousal resonate between these two types, it can be a divine fire, indeed. But when one is stressed, tired, or irritable, the other may just as strongly amplify those feelings. Sensitivity has its downside, and bad moods can be contagious. Avoiding this pitfall requires conscious corrective action, and it isn't always easy.

When confronted by something negative, it's important to manage internal reactions. These lovers must refuse each other's negativity before it works its way into the heart of the relationship. If one partner is upset by something external to their relationship, the other can help by expressing sympathy *without* sharing their outrage – and they can go further with a positive gesture like a brief shoulder rub while their

partner is venting. In a relationship, these types can help each other by:

- Taking time alone to focus on personal thoughts and emotions.
- Balancing time spent together and socializing with others.
- Gently declining to participate in each other's negative emotions.
- Projecting supportive, positive feelings in the face of each other's upset.

There's no magic bullet to prevent or resolve strong negative emotions, but putting their underlying care for each other into practice can see these couples through conflicts. Emotional individuality during good times can bolster these partners when the going gets rough.

Balancing Dreams with Responsibility

To achieve balance between grand hopes and necessary realities, Mediator-Diplomat couples must learn to engage in the present while still honoring their expansive, creative tendencies. One way to do this is by regularly participating in hands-on activities together. Working on home improvement projects, shopping together, and being social with others are great ways for these couples to enjoy the moment yet still enjoy each other's inspired company. Having grand dreams is good, but putting energy into practical activities together ensures that they don't end up living with their heads constantly in the clouds. This balance helps prepare them for dealing realistically with more serious matters as well.

When less pleasant responsibilities come knocking, Mediators and Diplomats can roll up their sleeves, put on some music, and try to make the work as fun as possible. Whether it's fixing a leak, cleaning a room, or saving enough money for bills, both of these types benefit from companionship and help – working together with a cheerful attitude creates momentum. No instruction can instill the needed will to accomplish responsibilities, but these steps can bolster these couples' commitment to getting things done:

- Make time every week to complete minor, in-the-moment pursuits together.
- Pick a chore day and make it a permanent part of the weekly schedule.

- Ask each other what daily chores are being overlooked, and cooperate to get them done.
- Keep a list of needed chores and errands, and share the execution of list items.
- Avoid putting things off. Do chores and errands as soon as possible, together or independently.

For types so likely to get lost in their own imaginations, it's very important to take action. From simple camping trips, designing and building gardens, to sweeping the floors, these couples can push themselves to move past the hoping and dreaming phase and get to work on their goals.

Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

These relationships often bring about a kind of warm support that makes both types feel secure and very well cared for. Mediators' deep value of harmony with those close to them combines with Sentinels' sense of stability to create a love that fulfills each partners' needs very well. They may have radically different approaches to life and internal motivations, but both place tremendous emphasis on having genuine, trusting love in their lives, and this appreciation opens them up to learning from each other's differences.

Balanced Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

A Foundation of Mutual Benefit

Sentinels and Mediators share outlooks that can enable great relationships. Both types sincerely want what's best for people – Sentinels create

stability and continuity, and Mediators foster kindness and emotional support. These couples place great emphasis on their values, and while they may have different approaches to promoting their ideals, their underlying desire for harmony is a lifelong practice. Balanced Sentinel-Mediator romantic partnerships combine their somewhat distinct values and are based on mutual support, something that love easily brings out in both types.

One of the best things about Mediator-Sentinel relationships is how they compensate for each other's behaviors. Sentinels can be a grounding influence on sometimes flighty Mediators by providing them with a stable perspective. Mediators can provide their Sentinel lovers with deep understanding and empathy, as well as a needed dose of inspiration. Their rich fantasy lives and gentle adventurousness can help Sentinels break out of their reserved shells and realize their own potential. When willing to appreciate each other's strengths, these two types can learn much about who they are and who they can become.

Building a Rich Life Together

Mediators aren't known for their pursuit of stability, but as they grow and experience life, they realize the difference between freedom and chaos. Just as painters need easels and musicians need their instruments, Mediators need the tools, knowledge, and resources to achieve their idealistic, creative visions. Sentinel partners are perfectly suited to helping them establish the underlying structure needed to pursue their ideas and goals. Sentinels are known for being practical, industrious, and sensible, and Mediators often need this kind of influence to move their lives forward.

Sentinels thrive on predictability, but even the most sensible goals can feel hollow without warmth and companionship. Mediators offer their partners heartfelt devotion unsurpassed by any other type. Sentinels' efforts to keep their lives in order are enhanced with deeper meaning when Mediators' love enters their lives like rays of sunshine – they can depend on having love at their side. Though they don't each bring the same things to a shared life, these two types build a more complete existence by embracing each other's differences and giving generously of their own virtues.

Unbalanced Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

Frustration with Follow-Through

Between these two types, partnerships don't always go as planned. Sentinels may at first be impressed by Mediators' idealism, as their focus on social values likely appeals to Sentinels' sense of what is right and fair. However, once that first impression fades, Sentinels may begin to question – at times justifiably – how practical Mediators' ideas are and whether they'll ever act on those ideas. Mediators who don't balance their imaginations with action may find their Sentinel lovers dismissing their flexible, optimistic vision as impractical. When Sentinels let their frustration get out of hand, they'll very likely hurt Mediators with their criticism, especially because there is often some truth behind it.

This frustration cuts both ways, though. Stabilizing is always on Sentinels' minds, and Mediators may initially appreciate the order that their partners create – it likely represents something that they lack in their lives. However, with their attention to tradition, Sentinels can seem rigid to Mediators, as though suffering from a lack of vision or an inability to change. If Sentinels cling to predictability, Mediators can become bored with the nuts and bolts of living in the present. Even worse, Sentinels who place too much emphasis on consistency can make Mediator partners feel trapped or suppressed, as though they can't fully exercise their curiosity and creativity – and to Mediators, these qualities are essential to a joyous life.

Different Timetables for Living

Mediators and Sentinels have potentially incompatible ways of scheduling their lives. Typical Sentinels come up with a composed and detailed schedule that they stick to dutifully, with everything in its place and on time. In contrast, Mediators prefer making things up as they go along and are comfortable abandoning something once their interest wanes. They take a very relaxed and flexible approach to engagement in the first place – things can happen whenever. Clearly, these two types can easily get on each other's nerves, especially since these different approaches affect so many common aspects of life, like meeting for dates.

Misunderstandings and irritation abound when these two types feel that their needs or perspectives are being overlooked. Mediators may

feel controlled when their Sentinel partners pressure them to solidify or stick to their timetables, while Sentinels can feel that Mediators are unreliable when they refuse. There's obviously great value in balancing planning with adaptation, but when these types refuse to move toward such a combination, disagreements about which approach is correct may turn toxic.

Rebalancing Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

Accomplishing Things Together

If both partners are open and willing to compromise, they can create balance. When they feel appreciated and appreciate their partner in turn, both will thrive. Mediators can accomplish things that matter to both them and their partners by acting with the same creative spirit that drives their imaginations. Sentinels, too, can keep an eye on practical matters that Mediators might normally let slide, while also being more flexible and open to trying fresh ideas and pursuits together. This doesn't mean that Mediators expect Sentinels to keep things in order by themselves, or that Sentinels can abandon themselves to the whims of Mediators – rather, they both balance unconventional ideas with sensible action.

Sentinels respect those who follow through on their intentions and are impressed when Mediators show a willingness to roll up their sleeves and get to work. This respect extends beyond practical or routine matters into personal interests as well. Just as Sentinels appreciate Mediators' participation in everyday responsibilities, Sentinels can also recognize the value that Mediators derive from working on their creative dreams – and the truly dedicated Sentinels offer their help. Laundry and finances are important, but for Mediators, life is pointless without being able to dream their dreams, and Sentinels who want to create balanced, full relationships support their partners' personal priorities. Some basic steps that can help these two share priorities include:

- Be patient with each other's limits and needs.
- Give time and energy to each other's goals, whether mundane or zany.

- Decide priorities together, including completion times.
- Set aside time every week for a session of work together.
- Work together, and try to make it fun – without losing sight of goals.

A strong, loving commitment to each other can serve as an underlying reason for these partners to be supportive – creative imagination and stable convention need not be at odds if each type is willing to share their time and energy on what matters to the other.

The Best of Both

In real terms of everyday shared lives, rebalancing these couples' scheduling differences means compromising so that both types have what they want some of the time. Sentinel partners can learn to be more spontaneous, even if it means occasionally relaxing a schedule (or even going without). They can also recognize the importance of respecting Mediators' freedom and their right to change their minds. Experiencing love and joy together gives Sentinels motivation to be patient and accepting, and given how sensitive and concerned Mediators are, they're unlikely to push their partners too far out of their comfort zones.

In fact, Mediators can use their "go with the flow" attitude to their partners' benefit, letting Sentinels organize and direct plans and activities that are important to them, especially those that are time sensitive. Although overactive imaginations can conjure plenty of arguments otherwise, tidy schedules rarely cause conflict, and most Mediators benefit from increased structure in their lives. They can simply relax and let Sentinels handle their schedule, ensuring that they're ready to participate when needed and knowing that just as they revel in – and deserve – their wild and free moments, Sentinels also deserve the satisfaction of things being on time. Here are some steps that can enable workable compromises:

- The Mediator comes up with fun ideas, and the Sentinel partner plans these experiences so that both can find enjoyment.
- When timeliness is needed, like when arriving at the airport for a flight, agree on plans together, and include a little extra time just in case.

- Ensure that each type's part of the plan is completed on time. Gently remind each other of approaching deadlines.
- Engage in unscheduled time together to explore in a moment-to-moment context. Fairs, farmer's markets, and other free-form events of mutual interest fit the bill.

Each type in this coupling has certain strengths, and both types can take a step into each other's timeframes now and then. When it comes to recreation, Sentinels may find it an unexpected relief to let go of rigid control, and Mediators can appreciate the benefits of staying on schedule when it comes to important matters.

Mediator-Explorer Relationships

These pairings offer partners many adventures as their differences combine in interesting and exciting ways. Mediators have heads full of creative dreams, and Explorers tend to like hands-on activities – they may either baffle or inspire each other at times. Mediators' imaginations might not leap at the more material challenges that appeal to Explorers who, in turn, may become bored by imaginative talk of the intangible, but love itself expands the horizons of both types as they introduce each other to new things.

Balanced Mediator-Explorer Relationships

Exploring Reality Together

Mediators tend to get lost in dreams on their own, but with Explorers by their sides, they quickly find themselves drawn out of their heads

and into experiences. Unusual concepts appeal to both of these types, and when deep imagination becomes the launchpad for engagement, both can uncover new dimensions. When it comes to creativity and ingenuity, these couples serve as uniquely different sources of inspiration for each other, with Mediators providing a principled, highly imaginative perspective and Explorers excited to put ideas into a real-world context to see how they work.

Together, these types are interested in exploring everything, looking for what's new and exciting, and appreciating each other's styles of engagement. Explorer partners share Mediators' wonderful sense of curiosity, and they also carry that curiosity forward into action, trying to understand new things not just in theory, but in practice. It's very likely that these pairings result in lots of fun and adventure together, not only making initial dating easier but keeping things fresh as they progress deeper into loving relationships.

Freedom Together

Another quality that both Mediators and Explorers share is a love of freedom. To be happy, Mediators need to feel as though they can dream and create without restraint, and likewise, Explorers want to walk their own path by engaging in pursuits that are important to them. While they may have different focuses and approaches, these lovers share an essential desire to follow their hearts and minds wherever they may lead. When love grows between them, they support each other's liberty and passion. Because they know the importance of their own freedom, it makes sense to both of these types that their partners also want the freedom to explore. It's normal to them. Whereas some types might feel compelled to impose structure or restrictions, these two types likely just say, "Go for it, babe!"

If loving something means setting it free, then Mediator-Explorer couples can truly find empowerment in loving each other as they embrace their dreams and goals. When a solid emotional connection ties them together, Mediators can happily grant their Explorer partners the time and space they need to master whatever they set their sights on, and, in turn, Explorers are unlikely to deny Mediators their grandest hopes and ideas – though they might encourage them to do more than just dream. These couples don't hold each other to rigid standards or

convention by any means, as both are willing to adapt to new things all the time – and even seek them out. When balanced in their support of each other's interests, they can find endless happy adventures together.

Unbalanced Mediator-Explorer Relationships

Why Don't You Understand Me?

Despite their shared curiosity and adaptability, Mediators and Explorers have some significant differences when it comes to imagination versus practicality. Mediators who take their imagination too far can essentially end up living in a world of self-affirmed realities where what's correct is based mainly on their own internal vision. An unending obsession with concepts that never reach the real world can make even the most flexible and permissive Explorers shake their heads in vexed wonderment. These types may lose patience with Mediators who can't bring themselves to face realities that they don't like, and, in turn, Mediators may see Explorers as sadly limited by their inability to accept intangible truths.

Explorers specialize in real-world experimentation – they actively practice fitting things together, with their ingenuity based heavily on adapting to feedback from their environment. When something doesn't turn out the way they hoped, they try a different approach. Mediators, on the other hand, think about how purely conceptual or intangible things *might* fit together and can become blinkered by possibility. When something doesn't go as they hoped, these types often adapt to preserve the vision in their heads. By fixing theoretical discrepancies in their minds, Mediators avoid having to test their more outlandish ideas in the real world.

Shifting Sands

These lovers usually share enthusiasm for all that's new and unknown, but their willingness to dive headlong into change may result in shared risk. While they might not lack for love and joy, even those things can be threatened if their lives become too chaotic or fail to meet their basic needs. Prosperity, long-term success, and the achievement of

dreams often requires steady commitment and effort in ways that don't immediately pay off. These couples' love of newness and change may distract them from less thrilling, but no less important and rewarding, investments in themselves and their future, as they're often gleefully willing to shirk responsibilities.

Whether it's failing to decide on an area of study, switching jobs too often, or simply frittering away their time and resources on pleasure together, Mediators and Explorers are, by their very natures, in danger of building their futures together on shifting sands rather than worthy foundations. Most people don't possess great wealth, and so this can be a pernicious problem. If these types let their novelty seeking get out of hand, they may not stick to the same goals for very long, and while this may be fine in discretionary personal pursuits, it can stall them in matters of long-term development which are important to creating happy, successful lives.

Rebalancing Mediator-Explorer Relationships

Flexible with Each Other

Reconciling differences between airy, conceptual idealism and hands-on practicality is a much-needed step for these couples to achieve balance. Luckily, their mutual willingness to try new things offers them a clear path to accepting, if not always understanding, each other's styles. With a little tolerance, these two types see the value in their different methods – Mediators see how well Explorers figure things out through direct engagement, and Explorers see how insightful Mediators can be using only their minds. The combination of unbound imagination and practical experimentation is probably a superior approach to either method alone, and with open minds, these couples can find a balance that allows them to operate together with amazing results.

One of the biggest steps is for these couples to acknowledge individual priorities in an affirmative way. Mediators can work to respect Explorers' focus on tangible accomplishments – they have every right to work on what matters to them. For their part in rebalancing, Explorers might consider turning their masterful abilities to helping their Mediator partners evolve some of their high-minded ideas into reality – at least,

the ones that can be translated into reality. Of course, Explorers can't be expected to merely occupy an intangible realm, so when Mediators ask their partners to join in, they must also be ready for action. Here are some steps to creating balance in this area:

- Give each other the respect and space to do personal things in unique ways.
- Explain their approach and why it's important to them, including how it makes them feel.
- Show personal and individual methods to each other and explain how they work.
- Try out the other's approach, preferably within an activity that's of interest to both and which can be done together, as experience creates understanding.

These types can tap into their love of novelty and explore each other's methods. The simplest way is just to join each other in personal pursuits with open hearts and minds – neither type needs to convert, but they can both experiment with different perspectives and methods.

Building a Foundation

Communication and cooperation are very important to rebalancing these couples' potential to meander through life. If they want to achieve meaningful long-term goals, they'll have to willingly take care of responsibilities together. Learning to regularly communicate about topics that are difficult or uninteresting is a sign of both personal maturity and mature relationships. Even if these partners are happily tolerant of disorder or prefer keeping their options open, talking through a budget, social schedule, housekeeping, and meal planning are essential steps to keeping their homes and relationships running smoothly.

Mediator-Explorer couples tend to dislike boring responsibilities, and this poses great challenges. While they may find happiness living outside convention, they do need responsibility enough to recognize what they'll need to remain content and secure in the long term. This may mean different things to different couples, but it typically entails more work, saving, or daily chores – and in any case, it requires a

serious attitude from both partners. In realistic terms, this means they dedicate time every week to attend their responsibilities together. These types may find it easier to maintain discipline when they view it as an expansion of their desires. These goals are for their own benefit. Steps they can take to help with goal setting and engagement include:

- Discuss and decide on a few long-term goals that are important to both.
    - What are they? Why are they important? What resources will they require?
- Define for each other what success would look like and how completion will be measured.
- When considering whether these goals are achievable, ask trustworthy people with related experience for their opinions and advice.
- Set a realistic timeframe for these goals, considering probable limits and other obligations.
- Commit to a schedule for working on these goals together.
- As you work, prioritize a positive attitude and encouragement.
- Stick to the plan as much as possible. Adjust only if necessary – an ideal plan accounts for variations and contingencies.

With a shared focus, these couples can translate their desires into real world results that keep them happy – not just in the moment, but for years to come. By working together, they can enjoy the benefits of stability as they lead spontaneous, light-hearted lives.

Conclusion

Staying True to Their Hearts

Mediators have a sensitive core that often makes it challenging for them to be bold, especially when it comes to critical social endeavors like romance. No other type is more sweet, thoughtful, and responsive to other people's influence, and it's this very receptiveness that grants them many advantages in love. Deeply empathetic and openhearted, when Mediators love someone, they not only welcome them into their

lives, they're willing to accept and revere them as they are. They can forge rewarding relationships with any type, and when they meet others who truly appreciate and respect them in return, balanced love knows no limits.

If there's any cautionary theme for Mediators in love, it's to not lose themselves completely in their adoration of their partners. These types so readily give of themselves that they may forego their happiness as individuals. Loving partners can give them what they need, either supporting them actively or just giving them time for themselves, but Mediators must remember to communicate these needs. Conforming to partners can create great closeness, but love only grows so much in an echo chamber – those who truly love Mediators want to see them honestly and will revel in their uniqueness.

When Mediators share themselves without shame, they may be surprised at how attractive they are to other people. Their ability to care for others on an emotional level, combined with their insightful imaginations and love of novelty and spontaneity, make Mediators appealing partners to all types of people. As Introverts, putting themselves forward socially comes with great effort, but they nonetheless benefit from doing so. Accepting themselves as wonderful and cherished can be a powerful step toward meeting their goals of personal growth – as well as finding true love.

Friendships

Private and Mysterious

Mediators are one of the most private personality types, a quality which comes through in all their relationships, including friendships. Despite this, they quickly "get" both their current and potential friends, as they possess incredible insight when it comes to other people. Even though they're adept at reading others, these types usually keep to themselves when it comes to their own thoughts and feelings. Mediators would rather direct a conversation toward universal ideas than reveal anything about their inner lives, at least until they can be sure that the potential confidant is receptive. They maintain this mysterious aura even with their dearest friends, and they require a profound sense of trust to let others in. This can make things interesting, albeit lopsided – in friendships with Mediators, the central task for both people is to create that trust. Nonetheless, if they want the friendship to work, they need to take that risk. There is no real friendship between two strangers, however appealing the notion.

The first step to having friends is meeting people, which Mediators find difficult. When they're younger, their sensitivity may cause them to choose solitude rather than face the stressors and emotionally charged situations that often come with even simple social engagements. This tendency may linger in older Mediators as well. Being alone may not bother them most of the time, but when they do yearn for supportive and stimulating relationships, they need to set aside their self-protection and reach out. For these types, isolation is more reflexive than intentional.

Sincerity and Authenticity

For their friendship, all Mediators ask in return is sincerity. Genuine behavior is vital to them, and they won't let people they see as inauthentic into their lives unnecessarily. These types possess a powerful filter that helps them determine who is genuine and who is not, so insincere candidates for friendship are usually revealed and left alone long before they get too close.

Mediators' preference for deep conversation over small talk helps them sort the potentials from the pretenders, and they're unlikely to form real friendships with mere acquaintances. The fact that individuals share the same spot in time and space isn't enough to warrant their commitment to a closer connection. Nor will they seek friendships based on everyday activities where chitchat is the chief form of communication. Passionate in their idealism, Mediators search for those willing to imaginatively climb to the greatest heights with them.

Supportive, Loyal, and Deep

Once Mediators establish a degree of trust and begin to develop genuine friendships, they're fiercely loyal, supporting their hard-won friends with singular devotion. Because of all the "trust work" leading up to their bonding, these types are usually unwilling to let something so meaningful slip away. Mediators show extraordinary levels of caring and compassion to keep their friends safe and happy.

Supporting and caring for others are integral to Mediators' identity – and they have hope that even those with the most abhorrent behaviors can be redeemed by love. Their personal view of support sometimes informs their opinion of how others should be with them. Mediators keep their circle of friends small, relying far more on depth than breadth. However, if they need lots of support, they have only a few kindred souls to lean on. This alone isn't problematic, but they may become needy or even overbearing in their friendships. Their chosen few friends receive the full weight of Mediators' needs, and it takes a special sort to balance it.

All friendships need some measure of trust, loyalty, support, and authenticity, but Mediators need these to be the defining elements. Add idealism to the mix and the depths of their relationships become quite profound. Because Mediators go to so much trouble to build

friendships, they treasure them greatly and are likely to keep such friends for life. Even though they're not always the most consistent people, friendship is one area where they're steadfast.

"I'm Going on an Adventure"

Invitations to Mediators' life journeys may come with some significant barriers. Finding friends willing to suspend their approaches to life long enough to share in Mediators' unique way of thinking and feeling is challenging. If they don't have substantial common ground to cement their relationships, it can be near impossible.

At the same time, Intuitive types can find it exhausting to convert their imaginings into something tangible, and Introverts can exaggerate their concerns about relationships, seeing other people as something to "deal with." For Prospecting types, there can even be a sense of apprehension about entering what might be perceived as a commitment from which they may need to extract themselves. For Mediators, a social life might seem like a burden.

To work through this, these types can reframe social interactions to appeal to their adventurousness, open-mindedness, and creativity – the parts of themselves that dream up grand stories and long to explore. Rather than "dealing with" people, they can try to see friendships as quests of discovery. In classic tales of adventure and fantasy, the occasional dragons do crop up – but that's what makes a quest so darn exciting!

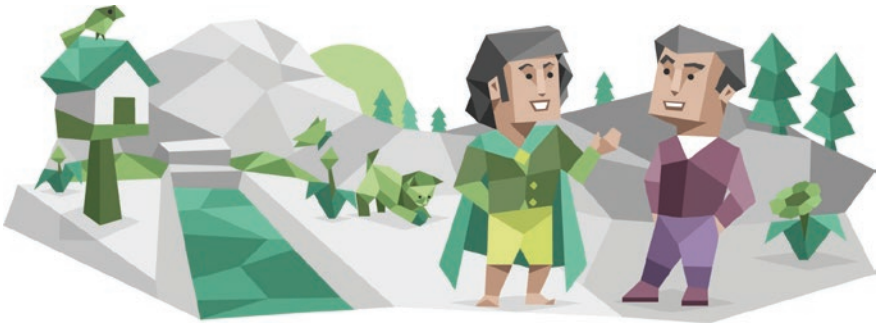
There may be confusion and chaos along the way, little embarrassments and miscommunications, but these setbacks emerge within a healthy friendship as part of a shared adventure. So much depends on the mindset with which Mediators build their social worlds. Will they be haunted by obligation and embarrassment – or inspired by quests filled with adventure?

Mediators and Friends from Other Roles

Friendship isn't simply about Mediators and some other generic person. Each Role – Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers – brings something unique to their friendships. How their distinct traits interact with Mediators' tendencies creates unique synergies and challenges.

The next four sections explore how Mediators and people from each Role relate to each other as friends. First, we look at what a balanced friendship looks like – when companions understand each other, lift each other up, cover each other's weaknesses, and enable each other's strengths. Then, we discuss an unbalanced friendship, one in which friends exaggerate each other's weaknesses or disregard each other's needs. Finally, we explore rebalancing friendships. Just because things hit a rough patch doesn't mean that they can't find a way back to positivity and mutual growth, and this chapter works to help friends do just that.

Mediator-Analyst Friendships



If a cartoonish archetype were created to represent an association between Analysts and Mediators, it might involve a scientist (the Analyst) and a poet (the Mediator). The scientist would explain things with unrelenting rationality and far more detail than was perhaps needed. The poet would rhapsodize in free verse, converting a clinical analysis into something almost beautiful. Although the caricatures represent a contrasting undercurrent that certainly exists, the two types aren't so distant – Mediators and Analysts can become great friends.

Balanced Mediator-Analyst Friendships

Unlimited Potential

Their interests usually differ, but Mediators and Analysts both share the Intuitive trait, which bestows a fondness for abstract ideas and "what if" scenarios, with Mediators offering the softer side of reality.

They certainly come from different perspectives, but their creative approaches and open minds come together beautifully. Mediators put heart and soul into their ideas, incorporating a sense of humanity and morality – even spirituality. Analysts put a rational spin on these ideas, always in pursuit of efficient, elegant solutions. Also, Mediators have grand visions for the future, but they struggle to work toward those goals in any tangible way. At times, they have trouble finding a realistic direction or deciding which of many paths is viable. Analysts can help Mediators bridge the gap between their dreams and reality. Their differences have the potential for conflict, but mature, accepting friends can complement each other wonderfully.

Mediators' plans change or evolve frequently, but for their dreams to come to fruition, they need enough stability to see ideas to completion. Analysts can be hit-and-miss on stability, but they add a dose of criticism that, although sometimes hard to hear (and not just because Mediators are sensitive – Analysts are notoriously blunt), can help shape a dream into something achievable. Analysts focus on rational plans that deconstruct concepts and systems to find their flaws and make them work better. This clarity can anchor Mediators' goals and dreams to make them feasible.

Finding Their Center

In a sense, Mediators and their Analyst friends act as interpreters and guides for each other. Mediators translate the world of humanistic concerns for their Analyst friends, while Analysts open the door to rational options for their Mediator friends. Mediators bring a softhearted approach to the world, choosing to believe in hope and kindness. In a friendship, this may rebalance Analysts' sometimes cynical outlook on the world.

Mediators serve Analyst friends as trusted guides on their journeys as well. Analysts are geared to consider logic before emotion. Some Analysts might even fear emotions, including their own, as representing a loss of self-control, a common misunderstanding about emotional expression. When Mediators help Analysts navigate this sea of feelings to understand themselves, it can add tremendous depth to both of their lives and to their friendships.

Unbalanced Mediator-Analyst Friendships

If either person leans on their core traits in an unbalanced way, there can be ample pitfalls in Mediator-Analyst friendships. This is primarily due to how they reach decisions. Rational, efficient Analysts and dreamy, empathic Mediators can certainly complement each other and hold each other accountable, but they can engage in some serious clashes as well.

Criticism as Support

Mediators and Analysts may have occasional tension in their friendships, especially if they aren't comfortable enough with themselves to be able to accept others as they are, which is a matter of personal growth. Tension can arise from the distinct filters that they tend to use to make decisions – it's emotional humanism versus detached rationalism. It's all too easy for these friends to forget at times just how differently they think. If forthright individuals feel strongly about an issue, they can easily upset each other.

Mediators are sensitive to criticism and tension, and Analysts are often gleefully provocative. When Analysts forget their Mediator friends' feelings, their behavior can become an unbalanced type of debate that can seem more like an attack. When Mediators forget that ideological arguments are akin to an intellectual game to Analysts, they can overreact with raw emotion, fleeing from the situation instead of playing along. Although their emotions may not be as near the surface, Analysts nonetheless feel such accusations very deeply when they come from a friend.

Profundity and Play

Mediators tend to take their ideas seriously, and they wish desperately that they could follow through with most of them. Applying their earnestness to their Analyst friends' sometimes bizarre plans could be disturbing. Meanwhile, Analysts may mistakenly interpret Mediators' ideals as being just as fanciful as their own. Mediators seriously wonder whether they should sell everything they own to pursue their dreams – change their lives so they might change the lives of others. Analysts treat Mediators' thoughts as they do their own. Consequently, they may trivialize what is most important to Mediators, hurting them in the process.

Analysts often brainstorm and come up with outrageous plans and ideas simply as an exercise in rationality. These types have no intention of their schemes leading to anything, even as they take a raw idea and refine it to the detail of a manual. For example, Analysts may talk at length about how to execute the perfect bank robbery, with surprisingly detailed knowledge of security and money-laundering practices seemingly conjured from nowhere – but local banks are probably safe. However, Mediators equate thought with action on a certain level, judging themselves harshly for any slips into the sort of amoral thoughts that Analysts can contemplate with relative dispassion. Seeing that their friends have no qualms with this can undermine Mediators' trust.

They can find each other intriguing at first, but if they don't work to understand each other, Analysts will keep trying to get their Mediator friends to take a break from fanciful dreams, and Mediators will begin to feel sadness for their Analyst friends who seem to see nothing as sacred.

Rebalancing Mediator-Analyst Friendships

Mediators and Analysts always have one thing in common: they share the Intuitive trait. This characteristic allows them to see the world with a broader perspective. With their mental flexibility, Intuitive types are the best equipped to find the understanding needed to rebalance a friendship as well as appreciate each other's strengths and weaknesses.

Friendships should make each companion intellectually and spiritually larger, not smaller. Each personality type should temper their thinking and appreciate the unique perspectives their friends bring to the table. Friendships between Mediators and Analysts provide opportunities to do just that – but first they need to acknowledge and set aside any intolerance of their differences just long enough to get to the people underneath.

A Teachable Moment

Mediators know well the strength that comes from emotional honesty and understanding. One of Analysts' greatest weaknesses is their

underdeveloped emotional intelligence – or, more accurately, their dismissal of emotional intelligence as valuable or even valid. Mediators have the patience and the skill with words (not to mention the emotional understanding needed to relate to others) to open this perspective up to their Analyst friends. There is an entire half of the world that Analysts just factor out of their calculations – those who rely on sensitivity and emotional context to make decisions.

There can be no better guides into this new world than Mediator friends. They prompt their Analyst friends to consider how others might feel, then help them adjust their plans and ideas. Of course, for proper balance, Mediators need to open themselves to similar teachable moments based on Analysts' more rational perspectives. The following tips can help:

- Understand that Analysts initially use logic in situations.
  - They're exceptionally precise people, which is why any emotional response they have will usually be a delayed one. Just as Mediators would have an issue stepping away from their feelings, Analysts would have an issue stepping away from rationality.
- When pondering on a seemingly emotionless response from an Analyst, try to:
  - Not immediately take it personally.
  - Take a step back from the response and consider whether it was intended to hurt.
  - If unsure, ask the Analyst as plainly as possible.

Appreciating Limits

Mediators hold their emotions very dear, and Analysts are notoriously insensitive to emotional cues. Mediators who'd like to balance out their Analyst friendships can start by letting their friends know that certain topics aren't game for criticism. This is hardly the ideal way to start friendships, but for friends trying to repair damage, letting each other know that something is problematic is a sign of honest communication – something valuable in any relationship.

It's also an opportunity for Mediators' personal growth. These types sacrifice themselves for others' benefit, so standing up for their feelings can be a tremendous boost to self-confidence. Analysts respect such clear statements, and they're usually happy to oblige. Setting aside known flashpoints for conflict is straightforward and efficient as well. Having some informal rules when there are subjects that prove too contentious may help keep the peace, as well as keep these friendships from falling apart.

Here are some ways that Mediators can work on appreciating their own and their friends' limits:

- Consider a recent situation where you felt hurt or angered by a friend.
- Identify the specific issue and why it hurt.
    - For example, an Analyst friend tells you to "suck it up" during a time of great emotional distress. Such a statement can hurt, making you feel as though you can't talk to them when you need someone to turn to.
- Once you have the issue clearly defined, sit your Analyst friend down and:
    - Use "I feel" statements. ("I feel really hurt that my emotions were ignored yesterday," rather than an accusatory, "You're incredibly insensitive.")
    - Avoid any emotional flourishes or poetic language. Analysts do well with precise language, and they can understand an emotional dilemma better if it's delivered this way.
    - Be as straight to the point as possible but also clear. This is important because Analysts may have a harder time relating to Mediators' poetic descriptions of their feelings. If they're hurt, Mediators should simply say, "I was hurt."

Mediator-Diplomat Friendships

Mediators find a natural home with their fellow Diplomats. They come together easily, as their interactions are based on a common interest in humanistic topics, a strong concern for society and those adversely affected by it, and good intentions to make the world a better place. Considering all of this, it isn't unsurprising that Mediators and other Diplomats make for amazing friends.

Balanced Mediator-Diplomat Friendships

For Mediators, close friendships with fellow Diplomats can feel like befriending themselves. The common interests and shared temperament among Diplomats make for powerful influences. Diplomats live more internally than most types and exercise their imaginations extravagantly. This enables Mediators to sit quietly and comfortably with their friends without saying much at all. When they do talk, however, these types are unlikely to run out of things to say.

Because they're rare in a constellation of personality types, Diplomat friends work to maintain such precious friendships regardless of any difficulties they might encounter along the way. When they see all that they have in common, they strive to create lifelong bonds.

A Mental and Emotional Extension

Mediators who form genuine friendships with other Diplomats have the wonderful experience of gaining a kind of mental extension of themselves as they magnify their potential for joy and learning. Although Mediators are often overly private in their relationships, Diplomats can help Mediators express themselves in an emotionally

safe environment. Should Mediators overcome their caution and share with Diplomat friends, they'll enjoy relatable insights and gain the benefit and wisdom of each other's tests and triumphs. "I had the most amazing idea the other day..." is a common refrain in these friendships. In a sense, their honest and profound relationships offer each partner a chance to live two lives at once.

Likewise, Mediators and Diplomats are ideally suited to provide care for each other in times of trouble. An in-depth personal knowledge of each other's way of thinking combined with their nurturing nature makes them ideal confidants and emotional resources for each other. Each knows what the other needs or has the patience and understanding to find out. Sometimes they offer comfort, encouragement, and sympathy. At other times, they provide a firm metaphorical kick to snap friends out of a funk. The mutual understanding these types share may reach an almost mystical synchronicity.

A Creative Bond

When it comes to pursuing creativity and ideas together, Mediators find that other Diplomats make willing and helpful partners. In fact, mutual interests often bring these types together in the first place. They might build their friendships around reading a favorite genre of fiction, pursuing social causes, or even forming a band. Diplomats don't just "hang out." For these types, exploring life via deep conversations is relaxing. Mediators look for personal ways to express and understand such insights, often in very creative ways, and other Diplomats make ideal partners in such endeavors.

When Mediators and their Diplomat friends have mutual creative interests, they inspire each other to go deeper, spurring significant accomplishments and understanding. This supportive energy comes from core similarities tied to broad human and moral themes. However, they don't always think about things the same way. Differences between friends who feel that they know each other so well can be unsettling but aren't to be feared. They even hold special benefits. By weaving together their harmonious but independent paths, these companions can glimpse a different point of view that stirs up deep feelings because they're so similar and yet unique.

Advocate and Protagonist friends, who bear the Judging trait, bring a special gift to their friendships with Mediators. They help to ground Mediators in their creative endeavors, encouraging depth and follow-through. Mediators' approach to life is a lot more inspiration oriented than that of Judging Diplomats. Although Mediators' flexibility and lack of conformity can certainly lead to something beautiful when their creative juices are flowing, it's just as likely that they'll only hint at that beauty before moving on. Judging Diplomats may be able to help their Mediator friends focus on their goals, and perhaps even meet them.

Unbalanced Mediator-Diplomat Friendships

Isolated and Insulated

Adding varied thoughts to the mix can make ideas stronger. However, Mediator-Diplomat friendships sometimes build a psychological "bubble" that keeps them insulated from the critical input of outsiders. This is magnified if the friends are also Introverts. A bubble is a cozy place for private Mediators, and it's tempting to take advantage of relationships that promote such isolation.

The key challenge for Mediator and Diplomat friends comes from the same source that fuels their friendships – their similarity. Having friends who think the same way is reassuring and comfortable. However, when they're isolated from diverse opinions and rely only on each other, these types can find themselves lacking useful feedback and perspective. This creates the risk that they'll support each other's ways of thinking despite critical flaws that more objective types would quickly notice.

Subconscious Manipulation

Similarity might also lead Mediator and Diplomat friends to manipulate each other subconsciously. Mediators don't consciously seek power over others, especially through manipulation, and they aren't likely to try to pull the wool over another's eyes. Their empathy and their quest for genuineness stifle such impulses. Nonetheless, they do know what makes other Diplomats tick. If their friends have an agenda that doesn't quite match theirs, Mediators may find themselves bending the rules and subtly discouraging their friends from certain paths by showing a

little extra disappointment. They know what kind of doubts resonate, and manipulation can become accidentally effortless.

Mediators' deep trust allows them to be manipulated by people they care about too. These types are "harmonizers," often willing to quickly set aside their own needs in favor of their friends' needs. This can lead to a sort of manipulation if friends use Mediators' need for harmony to their own benefits. Despite the empathic gifts typical to Diplomats, trust can run so deep between these friends that they neglect deeper concerns about fair and humane treatment. People sometimes aren't even aware of these unhealthy influences existing in their friendships.

It's important to keep in mind, however, that manipulation and compromise are two different things. The thing to ask is, "Does one of us *always* get our way?" Compromise goes two ways, while manipulation tends to work for only one.

Rebalancing Mediator-Diplomat Friendships

Rediscovering the Tangible

Balancing their inner, imaginative lives with some real-world experiences is a huge benefit to Mediators and their Diplomat friends. Instead of only encouraging each other to live internally, these types can make it a point to get out and experience the world. Such an effort at balancing their lives – with local fairs, the arts, or live music – can only make their friendships richer. There's nothing wrong with watching and discussing a film, but perhaps a few frames of bowling or a spontaneous hike would expand their lives through novelty and variety. For a pair that otherwise lives through the imagination, a little interaction with the material world usually feels great.

Part of getting out into the world is meeting other people and including them in discussions and activities. This might be a challenge for Mediators alone, but with help and encouragement from Diplomat friends, they may be able to achieve it (finding events of mutual interest that allow for groups might be a good plan). Here are a few suggestions:

- Make time to learn real-life skills together (e.g., woodworking, cooking classes).

- Focus on things both enjoy that require attendance or active participation.
- Try and pick things that exercise basic skills in a hands-on way, such as painting or tennis.
- Spend time with other types of friends to avoid isolation.

Thinking Critically

Mediators and Diplomat friends can rebalance subtle manipulations by focusing on sharing their own feelings, thoughts, and ideas. These friends carry a certain gravity with each other because of the trust inherent in the relationship, but there is a difference between subtle pressure and honest, gentle sharing. That may be a difference that Mediators want to fine-tune, especially in friendships with Diplomats, where emotions abound and harmony is prized over all else. Mediator-Diplomat friends likely don't want to reject each other's criticisms or concerns when they come from a good place, but realizing that manipulation can also take this form will raise awareness when it's happening.

Words like "manipulation" may sound harsh or unlikely, but it's important to understand that we're talking about subconscious thinking, not deliberate machinations. In fact, conscious manipulation is a betrayal of trust that these sensitive friends find repugnant, and in that, we can see the key to rebalancing. Because these friends care so genuinely for each other's well-being, merely mentioning the appearance of any unfair pressure will hit home and likely halt it. When one of these friends takes the time to gently express their concerns, the other will quickly look at their own behavior anew and then do whatever it takes to restore balance. Here are a few pieces of advice that can help restore balance:

- Express criticism as constructive concern, openly and without emotional pressure.
- Don't be afraid to respectfully consider but reject each other's advice.
- Make appreciation clear to each other while staying firmly on a personal path.

- Try not to get too caught up in each other's emotions. A little distance can enable better objectivity and, ultimately, better care for each other.

It's important for these friends to be supportive, not controlling. It's enough to honestly make their opinions known and offer their help to each other – they don't need to feel responsible for each other's decisions nor take each other's independence as rejection. Instead of trying to push each other subtly, they can give their support to the directions each chooses for themselves.

Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

Mediators and Sentinels may seem like opposites – the hopeful dreamers and the keepers of society don't seem like they would be a natural fit. However, their opposing traits can be balanced out if both are willing to work together to create a strong and everlasting friendship.

Balanced Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

A Study in Contrasts

Sentinels, as the most common personality types by far, likely make up some if not most of Mediators' circles of friends. This is despite some marked trait differences between these types. The closest Sentinel match to Mediators are Defenders, who share the Introversion and Feeling traits. Executives, however, differ on every core attribute. Nonetheless, they have a common interest in caring about others. For Mediators, this comes from a kind of dreamy, romantic sense of

altruism. For Sentinels, it originates from a more practical place, rooted in everyday concerns, common sense, and loyalty.

In the right spirit, Mediator-Sentinel friends can use their differences to share the best of two worlds. While Mediators explore the vast reaches of their imaginations to discover how the planet might be a better place, their Sentinel friends work on it in detail with steady, measurable progress. When Mediators reveal far-flung utopian ideas to their Sentinel friends, Sentinels temper the concepts with practical considerations. When Sentinels embrace the more pedestrian aspects of life, Mediators can pull them toward more interesting ways of considering their existence and possibilities for society. A dialectical push and pull between such friends evens out extremes, and stretching in these ways promotes growth for both.

Feet on the Ground, Heads in the Clouds

Mediators balance their Sentinel friends' perspectives by taking them on tours of profound thoughts and unusual perspectives. Their influence can help Sentinel friends to mitigate boredom, breaking them out a bit when life becomes confining. Mediators can help Sentinels relax their tendency to be adamantly purposeful, providing them with relief from their abundant responsibilities. Mediators help their Sentinel friends balance their approach to spontaneity, flexibility, and fancy. "We don't need a plan," might be the Mediator's rallying cry to their regimented Sentinel friends.

Mediators see life creatively and hopefully by way of their imagination, whereas Sentinels focus on far more concrete matters. When Mediators wrap themselves up in thoughts and theories, they can expect Sentinel friends to draw them out of their reverie and into the material world. After chatting about the nature of humanity or watching thought-provoking movies, Sentinels may get their Mediator friends to the park or out for a day of shopping, at least occasionally. Sentinel friends can help Mediators appreciate and enjoy life in more tangibly fun ways.

Such friendships involve companions sharing their distinct views of life. Mediators peer through a looking glass that whisks them away from the here and now, and Sentinels use a magnifying glass to appreciate the controllable details that are within reach. Both can be interesting

perspectives. Such friends might suggest to each other, "Here, try looking at things through mine for a minute."

Unbalanced Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

Stubborn Misunderstanding

Trouble can begin in Mediator-Sentinel friendships when either insists that their way is the better way. Mediators may have more patience with Sentinels who possess the Feeling trait (Defenders and Consuls), but they may hit a brick wall with Thinking Sentinels (Executives and Logisticians). When Sentinels hold on to their established patterns and Mediators hold onto their ideals, it can be an unstoppable force meeting an immoveable object.

Instead of relying on the steadying influences of their Sentinel friends, Mediators may be tempted to think of themselves as deeper and more substantial. These types can be very intensely involved with their own thoughts and feelings, which is why they sometimes make the mistake of believing that others cannot possibly feel or see life as they do. Mediators disregard the everyday details that Sentinels often painstakingly attend to – Mediators will discard tradition, community, and the status quo if they're not in line with their personal ideals. Sentinels can feel frustrated by this disregard, and when they insist on their own values, Mediators may condescend. In the eyes of Sentinel friends, that comes across as out of touch elitism.

The Concept versus the Details

These friends can balance each other's lives, but if they criticize each other's methods, such behavior can lead to conflict and tension. Both types tend to have an idea of what they want to achieve, but they may go about it in very different ways. Mediators organize their worlds around opportunity and inspiration, whereas Sentinels organize their worlds around details and stability. This can become an issue when they try to work together toward a common goal, such as a social endeavor or shared outing.

Mediators' focus on the intangible becomes unbalanced when it leads to indifference or irresponsibility, such as the details of executing

mutual activities. They may act based on unrealistic expectation more than sensible assessment, causing plans to falter or go awry in ways that frustrate Sentinels, who think they can see how problems could have been avoided. Sentinels, on the other hand, might insist too rigidly on details, hanging their own – and others' – happiness on procedural matters instead of a broader outcome of fun and enjoyment. Although neither intends to be intolerant of the other's style, it can turn out that way when these friends make plans together.

Rebalancing Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

Appreciating Fundamental Differences

For these types, having fun together requires an understanding that they may have divergent definitions of fun. One of the first steps to closing the gap between Mediators' conceptual focus and Sentinels' pragmatic view is simply to acknowledge that difference. Although there may never be a full meeting of the minds, there can be a meeting of the hearts and a sense of acceptance and mutual respect. With patience, each can work to understand that the other is coming from a good place, which creates common ground for enjoying each other's company.

It's a fool's errand to ask Mediators to be less passionate or Sentinels to relax their need to maintain practical control. However, the best way forward is to experience each other's worlds, at least a little – they needn't lose who they are or cease counterbalancing each other. Sentinels can still ask their Mediator friends to take a deep breath when they're too distracted with new ideas or passions, and Mediators can still ask their Sentinel friends to lighten up a bit when they're obsessed with serious responsibilities. The mere intent to accept and explore each other's ways a little at a time will be enough to rebalance this caring friendship. To achieve this, both friends can do the following:

- Respect each other's differences.
- Ask questions about how each other's differences are applied in daily life.
    - When they have differences in opinion, Mediators can gently inquire why Sentinels do things the way they do.

- Try and glimpse things from each other's point of view.
- Make time to do things together that appeal mainly to one friend, then alternate fairly.

Whether it's a movie or politics, these two will likely always have to make room for each other's different styles. However, belief that their approaches are just fine for themselves also means that they must give each other the respect to do things their way – treating each other as they wish to be treated.

Understanding Is Caring

Mediators should recognize that it's no small thing to disrupt Sentinels' best-laid plans. Sentinels take their responsibilities seriously, and they can harbor hurt feelings over disruptions of their code, even those that seem minor. Mediators can rebalance such missteps not only by letting their compassion open the door to compromise but also by taking time to appreciate what Sentinels contribute to shared plans. It's great to have a grand concept of a fun shared activity, but ensuring that things are planned – and executed well enough to meet those lofty expectations – can lead to even more fun. Recognizing the value of Sentinels' realistic logistics not only demonstrates respect, but it also helps Mediators learn a skill that will help them accomplish their enthusiastic hopes.

For their part, Sentinels should try not to control every little detail – making something happen in a successful and fun way doesn't require absolute predictability. Sentinels are unlikely to allow themselves to be carried away by abstract concepts or stretched profundity, but they can open themselves up to being flexible and enjoying the moment. They can rebalance their rigidity by realizing that sometimes tight control of an endeavor severely limits its potential. Indeed, Mediators' seemingly "unrealistic" hopes may be the first step toward unexpected, amazing experiences together. Here are some tips that can help these friends rebalance their differing ideas of how to have fun:

- Join in things that matter to each other.
- Appreciate being with friends, even if the activity isn't very engaging.

- Try to respect the specificity of friends' needs, even if it makes no sense to you.
- Ask each other what to do to support each other's goals of fun.

Ultimately, friends are friends. Even though Mediators and Sentinels are sometimes caught off-guard by the distinct ways that they approach activities, they can have even more fun together when they focus on each other's unique contributions.

Mediator-Explorer Friendships

When Mediators and Explorers come together, there is no limit to the joy that can be had. Both have the Prospecting trait, leading them to venture the world as their will commands – just in different ways. Though some work is required, with ample understanding these two types can become the best of friends.

Balanced Mediator-Explorer Friendships

Two Kinds of Explorers

Mediators have much in common with Explorers. In a sense, Mediators are explorers (small "e") themselves. Like Explorers, they often go in nonconformist directions and approach life as something flexible and laden with possibility. Mediators and Explorers enjoy novelty, adding new elements to their personal worlds. Although Mediators usually focus on ideas and philosophies, Explorers home in on skills and experiences. They may show it in different ways, but they're both free spirits.

Mediators act as a stabilizing moral compass. Woven into their philosophical exploration, there is always a sense of empathy, compassion, concern for well-being and fairness, and a broad philosophy of humanism. This helps Explorer friends weigh the impact of their choices on others and themselves. Explorers help their Mediator friends realize that wondering and pondering are well and good, but sometimes, they just need to *do*. This can be especially potent in travel – bringing philosophical wanderlust together with, well, wanderlust, can open a literal world of adventure for these friends.

Discovering Beauty

These types help each other make many incredible discoveries that they'd never find alone. Explorers can coax their Mediator friends from their worlds of dreams and ideas and help them discover the sensual side of life. Mediators certainly enjoy the artisanal qualities of beauty and craftsmanship that Explorers all possess on some level, and they might even enjoy helping to build a fence or plant a garden, however much Explorers may claim that these are merely chores. Mediators may appreciate the novelty of working with their hands for once to build something practical. Also, time with their friends is always nice regardless of activity.

Mediators possess their own artisanal craft: the art of feeling and expression. Poetry shared with friends can be an outlet for the intimacy Mediators seek in friendship. With Explorers in mind, Mediators can shift their verse toward something more colorful, something exciting and hopeful for what life and the future can bring. They can even use their friends' moment to moment outlook as inspiration for a more immediate acknowledgment of beauty, perhaps in the form of a haiku, capturing the timelessness of the moment as the "Gold-green light filters / Through the trees on a shared hike / With a dear old friend."

Unbalanced Mediator-Explorer Friendships

Contrasting Approaches

Unfortunately, the potential for these types to bond is equaled by the potential to clash. One example is their lifestyle. Mediators are inspired by intangible values born from their imaginations and beliefs,

whereas Explorers find inspiration by connecting to the world around them, engaging in practices rather than rumination. When either of these types takes their own perspective too far, Mediators can become alarmed or Explorers can become annoyed with such unbalanced behavior – or worse, they can unfairly criticize each other's differences.

When this happens, Mediators can be quick to judge how Explorers should feel about things, especially in conceptual and social areas. They may think their Explorer friends are being selfish by focusing on accomplishing their own more tangible interests instead of sharing broader societal concerns. Explorers' concerns and activities often fail to contribute to societal growth and sometimes even undermine it. An environmentally conscious and generally considerate Mediator may fail to appreciate the technical gains to performance that their Explorer friend achieves by removing the catalytic converter and muffler from their car – creating added pollution and exceptional car noise in the process. In turn, Explorers who lose their balanced perspective may get annoyed at Mediator friends for expressing high-minded opinions, yet failing to follow through with any realistic ideas or practical action. Explorers have a great focus on personal accomplishment and little respect for what they may see as endless talk.

This isn't nearly as simple as a case of altruism versus selfishness, though. Explorers often maintain a "live and let live" attitude which at its core is highly respectful of others. Mediators pour their energy into their ideas and creativity, but that drive can easily become sanctimonious or guilt-based manipulation. The issue here isn't that one of these friends has an inferior approach, but that they can fail to respect how well their differing approaches work. When in sync, these two balance each other wonderfully, but if they allow their perspectives to become self-obsessed or narrow, their differences make for a slippery slope into judgment and resentment.

Mutual Disdain for the Mundane

Fun is just what Mediators need to pull them out of the clouds, but even with the best of intentions, these two types might step into an irresponsible dynamic. When things go too far out of balance, they enable each other to disregard consequences.

Explorer friends are likely to encourage Mediators to set aside some of life's obligations, pushing them to blow off a homework assignment or loosen a budget for a night out. For their part, Mediators easily get caught up in shared moments of joy with friends, happily ignoring rational concerns in favor of feeling good. These types may do little to moderate each other's compulsions.

This may not always play out in friendships the same way it would with roommates, families, or spouses. Nonetheless, friends can be a highly unbalanced influence on each other when they become each other's refuge from reality. While Mediators can maintain priorities, those priorities can easily become unrealistic, and too much fun indulgence with spontaneous Explorers only makes matters worse. Being supportive of each other can do unintentional harm when these friends don't discriminate what they support – inspiring shared experiences that can enrich the soul while leaving bank accounts dangerously impoverished.

Rebalancing Mediator-Explorer Friendships

Respecting Interests

Good friends often find interest in subjects that they don't care about simply because a friend cares so much. When it comes to their different approaches to life, Mediators and Explorers may need to be willing to not only overlook differences but also go along for the ride occasionally. Friendship is participatory. If either type is rigid and refuses to pay any attention to the things that excite the other, their relationship won't have much of a foundation.

Of course, in addition to adapting to each other's needs, Mediators and Explorers can have great friendships while maintaining separate interests too. In fact, they probably should. Friends of Explorers must appreciate their need to do their own thing. Mediators also have their preferences, and they may need to pursue certain things without the company of Explorers. On some level, such friendships may require sufficient distance and flexibility to allow the individuals room to be themselves. True friends don't need to share everything – they can give

each other space and then rejoin to focus on making plans that are rewarding to both. These steps can help keep both friends satisfied:

- Try to understand each other by discussing differences.
- Allow each other's differences without judgment.
    - Mediators could pause after their initial emotional reactions to Explorers' actions and step away from the situation.
    - They can give themselves time to meditate on the situation, perhaps a night to sleep on the issue, until they're ready to consider the situation again.
- When friction occurs, take time apart to engage individual interests.
- Come back together often for mutually enjoyable activities.

For Mediator-Explorer friendships to ultimately work, these individuals should have some interests in common, rather than simply tolerating each other's unique pursuits. Friendship should be a life-enhancing state filled with good times together. Sometimes this may require friends to take an unselfish step outside of their comfort zone or area of interest, even as they hold on to the values and interests that make them who they are.

Looking Out for the Little Things

Mediator-Explorer friends may both want to ignore their boring responsibilities, but because they care for each other, they should avoid becoming enablers and try to keep a caring, watchful eye on each other's well-being. Mutual support is a great benefit of friendship, even if friends share similar flaws.

This can be as simple as taking a moment to ask not only what would make their friends happy but also what would serve them best in the long run. When facing shared decisions about anything from life choices to recreational plans, these friends can add a layer of respect for each other by considering each other's welfare. Mediators are especially good at this and likewise deeply appreciate such efforts from Explorer friends. These friends can run headlong into indulgence together if they want – they just need to avoid overshooting the target or failing

to cover their basic duties. These friends can help each other by taking these steps:

- Try not to distract each other from life's responsibilities.
- Keep each other's well-being in mind when planning things together.
- Inquire about each other's availability based on consideration for other priorities: "After you're finished doing [blank], want to hang out?"

If these friends take time to observe what's going on in each other's lives, they'll see when it is or isn't a good time to engage in fun together. Prying each other away from stress is great, but it's important to recognize when to let each other focus on important things.

Accepting Noncommitment

Explorers may be uncomfortable committing to things – not because they can't follow through but because it transforms activities from joyful opportunities into obligations. This is quite the stretch for Mediators, who value commitment. Predictability never was the charm of these pairings, though, nor is it needed for Mediators to feel value in their relationships. Rather, that sense of unexpected inspiration makes Explorer friends important to Mediators who seek personal balance. Explorers pull them into the moment, where they can see the deeper dimensions of authenticity that they seek in life.

The key is for Explorers to find a balance between surprising Mediator friends and jerking the carpet out from under them. Mediators need consideration for their feelings, and frankly, a little hand holding goes a long way when leading Mediators into changes and the unknown. Explorers can make it clear that while their interests and direction make be subject to sudden change, their support will always be there. Instead of turning away to follow their own path, they can offer a friendly hand and the option to join, as this helps Mediators feel valued and respected whether they choose to participate or not.

Mediators care about their friends, and to create balanced friendships with Explorers, they can work to accept their unique qualities and needs. The stricter the arrangement, the less likely Explorers are to

be comfortable. Any efforts to control or direct them – something Mediators may want to do in reaction to Explorers' spontaneity – is likely to push them away. Mediators can moderate their desire for promises and commitment with appreciation for Explorers' spontaneity and how it can benefit them. Such friends will be ready to drop what they're doing and join them at a moment's notice. Here are some steps these friends can take to ensure their relationship is balanced:

- Be gently honest with each other when something isn't fun anymore.
- Be understanding when one of you wants a change.
- Try to manage expectations internally, and be flexible.
- When something's important, ask for – and give – the best effort to stick with it together.

Early and frequent communication can help Mediators and Explorers manage changing preferences between them. There's no better method than staying kind and considerate toward each other yet honest about changing individual needs.

Conclusion

Mediators are known for their never-ending quest to put things together in wonderful ways, and when it comes to friendship, this dance takes on a new dimension by incorporating the unique qualities and needs of other personality types. Mediators want to forge lasting relationships with people who share their values and perspectives. When these types open themselves to people who aren't immediately compatible or who challenge a Mediator's typical way of thinking, they'll find ways to grow through their friendships.

Mediators' combination of traits make them passionately progressive, but not always open-minded – they have deep values and a tendency to see the world in a hopeful light that can fail to account for a sometimes unfortunate or unfair reality. Friendships with people who don't completely share their perspective might not provide obvious reassurance, but ultimately, they may present even greater insights. Personal growth is about creating new understanding, and it can't

always be comfortable – similar-minded people may not give Mediators the chance to achieve their greatest potential.

On the other hand, friendship shouldn't feel like a lesson to be learned, always challenging the mind to expand. Everyone craves the comfort of trustworthy friends with whom they can share their deepest secrets, people who will stick with them through thick and thin. Yet it's important that at least some friends are simply fun and relaxing.

Fortunately for Mediators, personality types who are very different from their own can provide such comforts. Regardless of people's differing methods and perspectives, Mediators can almost always find something to appreciate and admire about other types. These types want to see the best in people. When Mediators follow their desire for connection into unexpected friendships, the rewards often exceed expectations.

Parenthood

Few challenges in life are so exhausting, yet so rewarding, as parenting, and Mediators are undoubtedly up for the challenge. These types bring the same amount of enthusiasm to their roles as parents as they do to their most passionate ideals. Mediators strike an impressive balance of gentle authority and inspirational companionship with their kids.

Mediator parents have several qualities that make them ideal guides, especially in how they relate to and encourage their kids. Their ability to both articulate their values and demonstrate the importance of developing a personal belief system is inspiring to wide-eyed, idealistic youth. These types often relate to their children in a magical, childlike way. This chapter describes strengths that can be embraced and areas that can be focused on to help Mediator parents maintain or regain balance as they help their children grow.

Compassionate and Supportive

Where others are quick to dismiss the complaints of their tiny progeny, Mediator parents take pains to make sure that their children feel heard. Whether talking their toddlers through their first boo-boos in need of a Band-Aid or helping teenagers overcome their first broken hearts, they've a steady supply of shoulders to cry on. Whatever their children's temperament and circumstance, these types meet them as they are with open hearts. Not that their children are the only beneficiaries of Mediators' kindness – these parents care for all creatures great and small, a quality that's sure to make an impact on any impressionable minds in their homes. Weaving respect for all life and all minds into

their children's growing psyches, Mediators extend their compassion and kindness into their children's fundamental worldview, creating empathic, understanding adults who carry these values forward.

In addition to being compassionate, these types are patiently supportive of their children. Rather than pushing their kids in the directions they choose for them or chastising them for having unrealistic goals, Mediator parents are the strong, steady wind at their children's backs and are quick to shift if their kids decide that they'd like to take a different route. Where some adults become frustrated at their children's stubbornness, Mediators understand that kids often act out in frustration at their inability to meet their needs or even communicate these needs to those around them. The extra time their children might need to overcome obstacles is time that Mediator parents grant with gentle patience.

Moral and Modest

Like all Diplomat parents, Mediators focus intently on morality. Rather than emphasizing rigid rules of etiquette to abide by, however, Mediators prefer to sincerely convey, through stories and meaningful conversations, the moral behavior that they wish to pass on. These parents encourage their kids to listen to their emotions when making decisions and not to be afraid of being sensitive and kind wherever possible. Having their children grow up as empathetic yet principled individuals is a key goal for parents with the Mediator personality type. At the same time, they respect the uniqueness of each individual and don't necessarily believe that any way of thinking is more "correct" than any other. As passionate as they are about their personal beliefs, they're equally respectful of other people's beliefs, so long as they benefit humanity.

Promoting morality is important, but in the minds of Mediators, there isn't one specific way that it must be done. Their modesty and open-mindedness prevent these parents from enforcing a strictly dogmatic method of moral behavior, leaving their children the option to find a system of embracing and promoting their morals and ideals that works best for them. This approach has the added benefit of encouraging kids to respect and appreciate the diverse methods that others use to develop their own morality rather than viewing these differences as "right or wrong."

Unstructured

While they can be downright transcendent when engaging with their children in the emotional, moral, and spiritual realms, Mediators often find themselves struggling in the earthly dimension that includes life's day-to-day mundanities. Structure doesn't come easily to these parents, who have a hard time understanding the values of consistency, details, and routine, prizing instead openness and possibility. However, for young children who are only beginning to grasp the complexities of the world around them, rules and schedules provide a comforting predictability to life's otherwise unfamiliar chaos. They also ensure that they're on time for the things that they care about and that small promises are kept.

Though freedom-loving Mediator parents may feel that open bedtimes and early sovereignty are ways of freeing their children from the artificial restrictions they rebel against, they'd do well to remember that kids don't understand how to use such freedom responsibly. Some mistakes can only be made once, and children depend on the wisdom of others. It can be helpful for Mediators who struggle with structure to have parenting partners who balance them out in this regard, but this isn't always possible. Without an effort to mitigate this – with calendars, sticky notes, or whatever else they need to keep track of responsibilities – their kids can struggle to develop necessary responsible behaviors.

Overly Sensitive

Their sensitivity and focus on morality mean that things other personality types would probably shrug off may hurt emotionally vulnerable Mediators deeply. Few things cause more anguish to these types than seeing their sincere beliefs about what is right and noble challenged or rejected by their children. In such circumstances, less confident parents can turn inwards, blaming themselves and becoming consumed with guilt for being unable to instill the right values. These types tend to be forgiving to all but themselves.

Parents with this personality type should be especially careful with their feelings during their children's adolescent years. Teenagers often rebel against their parents' authority as a natural part of their growing independence and identity development. Unlike their younger years,

rebellion at this stage is much more intimidating with the addition of raw emotions, higher intellect, and aggressive desire. Mediators shouldn't immediately assume that their teens are actively fighting their beliefs or that all their teachings were ignored. Conflict is no indication that a relationship is in jeopardy, and for many types it's a sign of trust – for kids to express their feelings to their parents is no small act. Yet Mediators who allow themselves to feel deeply hurt may try to focus all their efforts on mitigating damage and strengthening their relationships with their teenagers, provoking even stronger pushback.

Creating Structure and Rhythm

Perhaps one of the most beneficial things that these parents can do to build meaningful balance is to incorporate structure and rhythm in their kids' daily lives. Besides reducing stress and chaos, routines have the added benefit of providing stability for children, effectively decreasing the likelihood of mood swings and emotional outbursts.

While such creative types may balk at the idea of "structure" – equating that word with boredom and conformity – the truth is that, when used correctly, structure can provide *more* freedom to create and connect with their children. The adage, "In limits, there is freedom," holds true for kids of all personality types who rely on their parents to set safe boundaries that they can count on.

There are several specific ways that Mediator parents can create a rhythm and accountability system that benefits both themselves and their kids. Preparing for each day the night before – laying out outfits, tidying up the kitchen, making lunches, etc. – can make mornings less chaotic. Writing things down on a calendar, planner, or online scheduling app (that can be shared with their children as they get older) is another technique that's especially beneficial for sometimes scattered Mediators. Using timers and setting reminders can help to avoid last-minute rushes or forgotten appointments. Finally, these freedom-loving parents can also benefit from leaving room for spontaneity in each day and keeping their schedules simple and balanced. If they can prevent falling prey to society's pressure to overschedule their children in a multitude of activities, both Mediators and their kids can thrive.

Practicing Self-Compassion

Creating strong, empathic parent-child relationships is one of Mediators' top priorities. Even perceived rejection or indifference from their children can be heartbreaking for these sensitive individuals. Rejection, both real and perceived, is inevitable when raising children, and Mediators need to prepare themselves to deal with these situations in a healthy way.

Empathy can be both a blessing and a curse when dealing with stressful situations. While they can use their empathy in an outward manner, sharing in the feelings of those around them, these types can struggle with understanding their own feelings. When stressed, they may deprive themselves of personal compassion, exacerbating their feelings of rejection and isolation.

There are options for those who want to parent from a place of passion rather than one of fear of failure or rejection. Engaging in walks in nature provide Mediators a much-needed respite from the negative rumination they may be caught up in. Also, writing down their unfiltered thoughts and feelings can be incredibly cathartic for these types. (It's helpful to reflect on the transience of feelings when writing – what may be hurtful or frustrating now will inevitably change.) Burning or throwing away the words they've written can also symbolically "get rid" of negative thoughts or feelings. Centering activities such as meditation, prayer, and even deep breathing can be beneficial even in short five to 15-minute durations. When they're feeling particularly confused by their emotions, Mediators should seek out trusted friends or family members to share their feelings with. What may feel like a tangled mess of thoughts and emotions can be sorted through with the help of loving confidants.

Stages of Development

Each of the stages of children's growth present both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachment and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place

between birth and 18 years of age. It's important to remember that these stages aren't set in stone and the ages listed for each stage are *approximate*. Kids develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time.

The following paragraphs discuss what to expect at each stage of development as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Mediator personality type affect their parenting at each stage. We then offer suggestions on how to help Mediators turn an unbalanced approach around. Whatever the stages of development, growth never stops.

Building Bonds (From Birth to Approximately 1 ½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created by the parent meeting their children's needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants in their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, babies need to learn to trust that their Mediator parents can provide for them. If these types are inconsistent in providing for their infants, their children can have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachment.

Attentive and affectionate Mediators – especially those who engage in consistent physical contact such as snuggling or transporting their children in baby carriers on their bodies – can develop trusting, hopeful relationships with their infants and are likely to have little difficulty building comfortable attachment.

Balanced Infant Bonding

Building Loving Bonds

Mediators who tap into their empathy and sensitivity when their babies are born have no trouble giving their infants the attention and affection needed to build loving bonds. Infants need affection that goes beyond

just daily care. They crave the physical connection that their parents provide through cuddling, rocking, speaking softly, and making eye contact. Mediators' loving smiles do more than just entertain their babies – they create a primal connection that inspires the trust needed to create positive relationships.

In addition to affection and compassion, dedication is necessary for building trusting relationships with infants. Mediator parents are extraordinarily passionate individuals, and there's very little that they're more passionate about than their children. From the moment that their children are born, these types throw all their energy into making sure that their babies' needs are met, both physically and emotionally. Building trusting, loving bonds with their infants comes naturally to individuals with this personality type.

Open to Anything

While structure and schedules are certainly important during the infancy stage, flexibility and the ability to quickly adapt to changing needs is just as important. Midnight feedings, spontaneous crying fits, and unexpected diaper disasters are just a few of the ways that babies refuse to adhere to a schedule. Thankfully, Mediators are exceptionally flexible and find it relatively easy to readjust their expectations when situations change unexpectedly.

Caring for infants is exhausting. However, Mediator parents certainly appreciate the many new experiences that this stage provides – albeit maybe not until after they've recovered from their sleep deprivation. Nothing bores them more than a strict, unchanging schedule day in and day out, and they certainly won't have to worry about that with their new babies. While not all interruptions to their schedules are pleasant, they're enough to keep these parents on their toes and prevent boredom.

Unbalanced Infant Bonding

Neglectful of Their Own Needs

One of the less beneficial results of their passionate parenting is the tendency for Mediators to become so absorbed in caring for their

infants that they forget to take care of their own basic needs. Eating and sleeping can take a back seat to engaging with their newborns. Neglecting their needs to this extent can lead to health issues, both physically and mentally, if they begin to suffer from burnout and unhealthy eating, exercise, and social habits.

This imbalance is more likely to happen when these types aren't receiving support from their partners, families, or friends, who can both assist with child care and encourage them to take some much-needed time to care for themselves. These situations can become dire when a combined lack of support and self-care cause resentment and animosity in their relationships with others. Friends and family may feel completely neglected by Mediators in this state, while their partners may bear the brunt of their frustration and exhaustion. Feeling like mere ghosts of their true selves, parents with this personality type may run out of the emotional reserves necessary to nurture their connections with others.

From Dreams to Diapers

Many Mediators have a very idealized vision of what parenting infants should be like. Visions of sweet lullaby sessions in a cozy rocking chair and cooing over a smiling baby splashing in the tub are inevitably doused by the reality of all-night crying sessions and mountains of dirty diapers. This wake-up call can be especially shocking to dreamy parents who are unprepared for the massive responsibility placed before them.

Dreams of basking in the magical moments of infancy are eventually met with reality – parents are responsible for providing for their kids in an emotional way, and they must meet their children's practical needs as well. Achieving this level of security and stability can seem elusive to any new parents, and inexperienced Mediator parents may find the adjustment especially difficult.

Rebalancing Infant Bonding

Prioritize Self-Care

Learning to balance their needs with those of their children is one of the most important things Mediators can do. Taking a 30-minute bath while their partners put the kids to bed can help these types relax. Taking

relatives up on their offers to babysit can provide much-needed time to meet with friends for coffee. Even engaging in deep breathing exercises for five minutes can help to clear their minds and relax their bodies.

Additionally, all the relationships Mediator have prior to bringing their infants home undoubtedly go through a period of readjustment. It's vital for these types' overall well-being to make sure that they make their connections with others, especially spouses or partners, a priority so they don't alienate their support system. One simple way that Mediators can engage with their partners or other close friends and family members who play a significant role in their lives is to begin a gratitude practice. This can be done in a few minutes at any time during the day with the following steps:

- Choose a regular time each day – first thing in the morning, at supper, before bed – when they can communicate with each other face to face.
- Take turns listing three things that they're grateful for about their spouses, then listing three things that they're grateful for about that day.
- Discuss one thing that's bothering them that day. Avoid statements like, "My partner is the one thing bothering me" – these can easily negate all the positive things just listed.

Being vulnerable and expressing gratitude are both practices that promote intimacy between partners, which is vitally important to Mediators who crave understanding and connection. The healthier their relationships are with their partners and the stronger their network of support, the better parents Mediators can be for their children.

Finding Beauty in the Mundane

It's easy to see the beauty in those moments where babies are sleeping peacefully or smiling lovingly at their parents. However, beauty doesn't suffice in those moments when their infants won't stop crying or when the laundry is piled up so high that it resembles a geological formation. Most people would advise these types to just "deal with it," because parenthood is hard and not always lovely and magical. These types of reality checks can further frustrate already disenchanted Mediators. A

more effective (and enjoyable) approach to this problem is to purposely look for the beauty even in the most mundane moments.

Wabi-sabi is a Japanese concept that can be summarized as finding beauty in imperfection. Think of a handmade coffee mug, with its lack of symmetry and minor faults – part of the appeal of this item is that it's imperfect and has its own character and uniqueness. Rather than focusing on the stresses of keeping their home clean or dealing with a crabby baby, Mediators can use this concept to embrace these difficult moments and find the beauty within them.

The following steps can help develop a meditation or gratitude practice when dealing with the mundanity of parenthood:

- Choose a mantra that promotes peace or gratitude, such as "I am thankful for this day" or "Today I choose happiness."
- Repeat this mantra when doing any tasks that seem tedious or frustrating, like rocking the baby back to sleep in the middle of the night... for the third time.
- Practice countering negative thoughts, such as, "I'm going to lose my damn mind if I have to change another dirty diaper," into positive statements, such as, "I am grateful for this opportunity to spend time with my child."

Parenting is hard – often the hardest part of a person's life is raising another. And it's often discouraging, especially during those years when children are unable (and sometimes unwilling) to express gratitude or reciprocate affection. Rather than succumbing to disappointment when their dream of parenthood doesn't match reality, Mediators can embrace this opportunity for what it is – a chance to experience an incredibly beautiful and fulfilling relationship.

Testing Boundaries (From Approximately 1 ½ to 3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouth, and verbal communication are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, Mediator parents must provide safe harbor for their toddlers while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Kids who test boundaries, yet still receive parental support and encouragement, develop a sense of autonomy. Children who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries ultimately experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. These feelings can last throughout their lives and may ultimately jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as reliability or confidence.

Balanced Toddler Bonding

Trustworthy and Compassionate

Extremely supportive Mediators make an ideal "home base" for their children during this stage. Their engagement and determination to meet their toddlers' needs ensure that their little ones never feel abandoned, ignored, or unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) trustworthy caregivers, and these types don't disappoint.

Mediators' patient compassion is especially useful during the trying toddler years. While they can certainly be challenging, confident Mediator parents enjoy promoting their children's curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe environment. They take pleasure in helping their toddlers learn how to pick out their own clothes and dress themselves and promoting their children's natural creativity and self-expression. Helping their children learn to become creative, self-reliant, and competent are among Mediator parents' greatest joys.

Relatable and Respectful

If Mediators relate with greater ease than most to children – toddlers included – it's because they see the world through the same fresh eyes and appreciate how sincerely and authentically children interact with the world around them. These parents appreciate their children's struggles in a way that few other adults understand, with an empathetic

connection that facilitates honest, open communication. Due to their quiet, unassuming nature, many Mediators experience situations where they feel marginalized and misunderstood (flashback to feeling invisible at a restaurant or throughout *all* of high school), making it easier to relate to the frustration and helplessness that their kids may feel. This understanding makes these parents more likely than most to treat their children's requests – as well as grievances – with the utmost respect.

Relating to their children in such a meaningful way is certainly nice, but it is of little help when it comes to dealing with disobedience. Experienced Mediator parents work toward finding a balance between understanding the reason for their children's behavior while still enforcing the values they want their kids to uphold. They may realize that their toddlers' temper tantrums are due to missing nap time, but that won't result in legitimizing unacceptable conduct – especially if it repeatedly manifests as violence or disrespectful behavior. Clearly, values and morality aren't fully developed in children at this stage. That doesn't stop Mediators from consistently and gently reinforcing the behaviors they want to pass on to their tiny progeny.

Unbalanced Toddler Bonding

Taking Things Personally

This stage can be especially challenging for Mediator parents if they take their toddlers' willful or defiant behavior personally. When the children they've so lovingly raised begin using their newly acquired favorite word ("No!") in response to their parents' questions, it can be both frustrating and discouraging. From throwing a fit every evening at bedtime to refusing to eat any form of fresh produce (or any healthy food for that matter), toddlers often seem as though they're focused on challenging what their parents have taught them at every turn.

As much as they truly want to foster their children's independence, Mediators struggle when their children's behavior doesn't match their expectations. The toddler stage is where identity development begins, and kids are rarely going to behave in a way that fits their parents' personal mold. Behaviors such as hitting their siblings or yelling at their

parents – which, while not desirable, are normal for this stage – can be especially demoralizing to Mediators who feel that their children's moral development should be further along at this point. When these parents are more focused on these idealized versions of their children, they may miss opportunities to promote and support what's unique about their toddlers.

Too Permissive

Toddlers are professional boundary pushers, and Mediators crave harmony. Clearly these two mentalities are diametrically opposed, which can result in overwhelmed parents and domineering children. Rather than dealing with constant battles and temper tantrums, disheartened Mediators may find themselves caving into their toddlers' demands for more screen time or extra snacks.

Harmony is certainly valuable, but it isn't what permissive parents are creating when they consistently give in to their children's demands. Rather, they're telling their toddlers that if they just hold out long enough, they'll eventually get whatever they want. In addition to giving into their demands, permissive parents often fail to consistently enforce rules or consequences for unacceptable behavior. While they may believe that they're providing freedom and friendship rather than restrictive rules, Mediator parents who fail to uphold necessary boundaries are setting their children up for potential behavior issues, a lack of ambition, and poor decision-making skills.

Rebalancing Toddler Bonding

Promoting Responsible Independence

Pushing boundaries and defiant behavior are hallmarks of this stage, and while they can be extraordinarily frustrating, they're necessary parts of developing autonomy. Saying "no" is a way to establish boundaries, and developing boundaries is a fundamental component to identity development. It's easy to respond emotionally in such trying circumstances. However, that's not only unproductive but often exacerbates the situation. Mediator parents must take time to understand that their kids are establishing autonomy and aren't

intentionally looking to reject them. Once they change their mindset to one of understanding over frustration, these types can have more success in setting boundaries with their children.

Just because children are learning to set their own boundaries doesn't mean that their parents should allow them to get away with demanding behavior. Rather, understanding *why* their little ones are acting in this manner can prevent some of the Mediators' negative reactionary responses. Here are some ways that Mediator parents can approach potentially frustrating experiences (such as leaving the park) in a proactive rather than reactive manner:

- Upon arriving at the park, let toddlers know how long they'll be there.
- Start the countdown at least 15 minutes before leaving.
- Announce the time left in five-minute increments. ("We are leaving in 15 minutes... 10 minutes left before we leave... Okay, five minutes left.")
- Make sure toddlers hear the warnings, and make eye contact with them when possible.
- Walk calmly toward the children when there's about one minute left.
- Avoid the temptation to rush or leave quickly if possible. The more positive the experience, the more likely toddlers are to leave willingly in the future.

This process allows kids to complete any activities and ensures that they understand their parents' expectations. It also gives Mediators a sense of control – a way to be proactive and prevent temper tantrums – rather than just reacting to these outbursts with their own emotional responses.

Supporting with Structure and Discipline

There's nothing inherently wrong with Mediators wanting their kids to like them or in promoting freedom and independence from a young age. Problems arise when harmony and independence are prioritized above their children's need for structure and discipline. Toddlers

are incapable of understanding the consequences of their behavior, especially when their parents fail to explain or enforce household rules. Thankfully, it's possible for Mediators to maintain a loving bond with their kids while still providing the boundaries necessary to make sure that they're safe and well behaved.

Perhaps the most important thing for these parents to understand is that restricting their children's freedom when they're young teaches them how to be responsible with higher levels of freedom when they're older. Children who have never had to regulate their behavior or be accountable for their actions are more likely to engage in risky behaviors and take advantage of their freedom. Kids who gradually earn their independence, on the other hand, have greater self-control and a much better understanding of the potential consequences of their behavior since they've been disciplined in the past. Here are several steps Mediator parents can take to provide the structure and discipline their toddlers both need and desire to set them up for the most successful future possible:

- Make sure household expectations and rules are well known to all members of the family.
- Be consistent in enforcing rules and make sure that children know the consequences of breaking these rules.
- Reward positive behaviors with special privileges or treats.
- Enlist spouses, partners, family members, or close friends to be accountability partners and to assist when situations are overwhelming.

Thirst for Knowledge (From Approximately 3 to 5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately three to five years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and children at this stage accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Kids absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a seemingly infinite range of questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play (especially the unstructured kind) and lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through imaginary play and make-believe games and stories.

To master this stage, preschoolers must be given the opportunity to not only make some of their own decisions but also be allowed to initiate activities, ask questions – and receive answers – and lead others in exploration play. Children who aren't given these opportunities, or those who are made to feel as though their constant questions or childish make-believe games are annoying, can experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and a lack of competence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative.

Balanced Preschool Relationships

Natural Teachers

As promoters of lifelong learning themselves, Mediator parents genuinely look forward to inspiring their children to enjoy learning as well. They happily answer their preschool children's seemingly ceaseless stream of questions and take great pleasure in finding creative ways to engage with their kids in learning opportunities. From trips to the library to impromptu nature "classes" while walking to the park, these types take any chance they can to engage with and inspire their little ones.

Seeking out educational opportunities isn't the only form of teaching that Mediator parents engage in. Modeling morals and values for their children from a young age is just as important to them as any other form of learning. These parents teach their children to not only respect others but also appreciate their differences as well. Compassion is key with these types, and they'll go out of their way, quite literally, to model this behavior for their kids – like pulling over to help a stray or hurt animal even if they're already running late to school. Preschoolers can likely not only witness their parents' actions but also be involved in helping (in age-appropriate ways) with caring for any plants, animals, or people who need their help.

Emotionally Engaged

Life with their preschoolers isn't only about "teachable moments" for Mediator parents. Emotional engagement is their number one priority, both in terms of building strong bonds with their children and in

teaching them how to develop their emotional intelligence. Self-control, empathy, and interpersonal relationships (especially with peers) are all beginning to develop, and kids at this stage must have guidance to properly develop these skills.

Emotional intelligence is best learned through modeling, and this is where these parents can truly shine. There are few types who engage with others as authentically as Mediators. They're full of love and compassion for others and instinctually model these concepts to their children. Imaginary play is an especially useful outlet for practicing these skills. Something as simple as playing a game of "house" with their kids can be a perfect opportunity for them to both model healthy relationships and lovingly redirect less than desirable behaviors. Not only do they pass on their emotional wisdom, parents who engage in these types of play with their preschoolers enhance their emotional bonds as well.

Unbalanced Preschool Relationships

Prone to Burnout

The preschool years bring a new level of energy with them as children become more interested in making sense of the world around them. Kids at this stage are more mobile and opinionated than ever, which can try the patience of even the most devoted caregivers. Parenting is an exhausting endeavor, and this stage can be especially draining with kids' constant questions and need for stimulation. As an Introverted and especially private personality type, Mediators who fail to set up boundaries or find time to recharge quickly become depleted by the constant attention that their children demand.

Children aren't the only ones placing excessive expectations on parents at this stage. The preschool era ushers in an increasing number of play dates, swimming lessons, and art classes. In today's increasingly connected culture, there's an often unrealistic expectation that parents should be shuttling their children to every enrichment opportunity available and documenting it all on social media. Mediator parents who feel pressured to play into society's expectations can become overwhelmed, feeling the need to make every birthday party and family

vacation worthy of "sharing." All this running around and attempting to be "perfect parents" can quickly take a toll on these types, who would much prefer to focus on the meaningful over the marketable.

Struggling with Schedules

The same issues that can lead to burnout for Mediator parents are often the root cause of the schedule anxiety that they're apt to succumb to during this stage. The preschool years often bring with them an exponential increase in activities and expectations. Preschool classes, play dates, birthday parties, and community events geared toward children appear in excess as parents are expected to become more interested in educating and entertaining their children outside of the home. For Mediators, who abhor schedules and can struggle with making plans or being on time, this stage can truly test their limits.

As a Prospecting type, Mediators prefer freedom over itineraries. This laid-back mentality can spiral into irresponsible behaviors, especially for those who are less mature, resulting in their children being consistently late to classes or play dates. Tardiness, forgetting appointments and playdates, and failing to provide the funds for classes or field trips is a recipe for constant stress and frustration. While they certainly don't need to sign up to play chauffer for every class event or bring snacks to all the soccer games, these parents shouldn't assume that they can get by with frequent unreliability. If they fail to organize their lives in a way that works for both their sanity and their preschoolers' social calendars, Mediators may find themselves living in constant chaos.

Rebalancing Preschool Relationships

Readjusting Expectations

Rather than allowing their own and society's expectations to drive them to the brink of burnout, Mediator parents can learn to say "no" to the endless play dates and parties and say "yes" to taking a much-needed break whenever possible. Kids benefit more from having healthy, happy parents than they do from having birthday parties with designer cakes, pony rides, and goody bags worthy of being handed out at the Oscars. And these types benefit more from focusing on meeting both

their children's and their own needs in authentic ways rather than buckling to societal expectations.

While Mediator parents may initially feel some guilt for not "living up" to these often unrealistic expectations, they ultimately feel liberated from the unnecessary obligations. It's also important for them to find ways to take care of themselves amid parenting their preschoolers. Some ideas that can bring balance into this busy stage include:

- Determine the number of activities that feels right – one play date per week is fine and so is four – whatever works best for both parents and their children.
- Learn to say "no." While birthday parties and nature classes are nice, having a relaxing weekend or afternoon is sometimes more important.
- Know the signs of burnout and exhaustion for both parents and children, which can include:
  - Temper tantrums and spontaneous tears.
  - Extreme tiredness.
  - Feelings of anxiety or trepidation when certain events are on the horizon.
- Start small – try one class or play group for a couple of weeks to see if it feels right.
- Avoid the temptation to try to do too many things at once.
- Avoid letting others inflict guilt for not participating in every little thing.

Focusing on Sanity

There's nothing quite like parenthood to make Mediators aware of some of their most frustrating flaws. Scheduling, organization, and details in general can elude many of these types, and it's important for their sanity to figure out how to deal with these issues once kids enter the picture. While words like "structure" and "planning" can sound like torture to a personality type that thrives on flexibility, they can find

that building a daily rhythm into their lives provides them with more freedom.

Many Mediators, especially those who are parents, fail to take the time they need to recharge their Introverted batteries. A daily rhythm can provide the structure necessary to make sure that everyone's needs are being met while also ensuring that important tasks are being attended to. This rhythm can also create a sense of control, providing these parents with a reprieve from feelings of perpetual chaos that are a constant source of stress and distraction. The following tips can help them create a daily rhythm to help find sanity amid the bedlam of parenthood:

- First and most importantly, determine daily priorities that must be considered every day, such as alone time, family time, exercise, or time for engaging in hobbies.
- Utilize scheduling tools to help organize these priorities, such as an online calendar, a bullet journal, a day planner, or even a large family calendar hanging in the kitchen or family room.
- When creating a schedule for the day, make sure to include periods of time with nothing scheduled – this allows for flexibility.
- Figure out a rhythm that works best and commit to following that rhythm for at least 28 days so that it evolves into a habit.

Creating Competence (From Approximately 5 to 12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still constantly absorbing new information, they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported in these areas flourish in both their abilities as well as their self-confidence.

If they don't receive consistent support, kids at this stage can begin to feel inferior to their peers and are less likely to develop and work toward long-term goals. On the other hand, if they aren't sufficiently challenged, they can begin to feel overly confident in themselves and their abilities and come to lack modesty and compassion toward

others. They can also have difficulty coping with the inevitable failures that they'll face.

Balanced School-Age Relationships

Passionate and Encouraging

Often avid learners themselves, Mediators encourage their children to pursue their education with passion and curiosity. Passing spelling tests and memorizing multiplication tables aren't as important to these types as having kids who are creative and compassionate. If they feel their children aren't receiving a truly holistic education, these parents can explore alternative options such as homeschooling or charter schools to fill in the gaps.

Their empathic nature helps Mediators to quickly realize when their children may be struggling, allowing them to step in and offer their support before these situations get too serious. Their encouragement extends beyond academics, with support for their children's social and personal development as well. Knowing the challenges that their children are facing, these parents provide them with the tools necessary, such as empathy and compassion, to help them deal with difficult peers or frustrating fights with friends.

Spiritual and Emotional Mentors

The school years are a time of intense learning, not just academically but emotionally, spiritually, and socially as well. Mature Mediators excel at modeling the skills needed to be compassionate, considerate, and motivated individuals. Yes, children need to learn mathematics and writing, but if their education fails to incorporate human elements like spiritual and emotional needs, they ultimately end up confused and unfulfilled. Parents with this personality type go out of their way to ensure that their children find meaning in everything they do. They encourage them to pursue passions that focus on innovation and creativity over the rote memorization that's often expected at this stage.

At a stage in life when kids are constantly being told what to do and required to conform to strict schedules, innovation and creativity often become neglected or viewed as unnecessary. Imaginative Mediator

parents encourage their kids to incorporate their unique ideas and perspectives into both their academic and personal lives. They encourage their children to integrate their passions and causes into these areas as well – from science projects focused on solving issues surrounding global warming to organizing a student council community volunteer day. Few types are as effective at inspiring and promoting passion into their children at this stage as Mediators.

Unbalanced School-Age Relationships

Struggle with Confidence

One of the most important skills for kids to develop during their school years is confidence. From persisting on a difficult school assignment to standing up for a friend who is being teased, confidence is what gives children the strength to work hard and do the right thing. Mediator parents who may have lacked support or encouragement during their formative years are especially likely to lack confidence in their own abilities. Struggling in a school setting or being belittled by domineering parents or teachers may come back to haunt these types, preventing them from developing – and therefore modeling – the confidence necessary to thrive.

If they fail to overcome these barriers themselves, Mediator parents run the risk of raising children who shut down in the face of adversity. It does little good to tell a child to "stand up for what they believe in" and to "persevere when the going gets tough" if they fail to model these behaviors in their own lives. Their kids won't only struggle with their own confidence, but may see their well-intentioned parents as hypocrites that fail to "walk the walk" when things become too challenging.

Overly Idealistic

Mediators' passionate idealism can cause issues for their children at this stage if it isn't properly balanced with their children's needs and abilities. School-aged kids certainly benefit from being concerned about protecting the environment and practicing compassion toward all living things. However, they also need parents who can help them address some of the practical issues they may face daily. From a school

crush that isn't reciprocated to the trauma of being picked last for the kickball team, children at this age need parents who can help them deal with personal issues that deeply affect them.

If they're constantly focused on the bigger picture, Mediator parents can fail to validate their children's feelings on these "smaller issues" and find that their kids are less likely to seek their help or support in the future. Sure, the world isn't going to end if their children don't make the basketball team, but it can feel catastrophic to children at that age when everything that happens to them is a big deal. Parents who don't recognize this and don't help their children put things into perspective can ultimately struggle to maintain close relationships with them.

Rebalancing School-Age Relationships

Promote Confidence

The beauty of confidence is that it's a skill that can be developed at any age – it's never too late to improve this trait. Parenthood is a very effective motivator, and Mediator parents have every desire to help their kids be successful in life. Individuals with this personality type are put off by self-promotion and any behavior that they view as self-serving, and they must overcome their misguided belief that being confident somehow equates as being arrogant.

Mediators can also keep in mind how important it is for their school-aged children to develop a sense of competence to effectively move through this stage. Children should be encouraged to take pride in their work and be taught to view failures as new opportunities. They thrive when their parents acknowledge their achievements, and it helps them learn that their hard work can pay off. Hang spelling tests that they ace on the refrigerator and celebrate with extra dessert after dinner or a (slightly) later bedtime that weekend.

When their children fail, Mediator parents can help them dust themselves off and look for the light at the end of that proverbial tunnel. Didn't make the dance team? That's fine – they can join cheerleading or debate instead! Kids who realizes that failure isn't the end of the road but rather the beginning of another path are likely to be more

confident and successful throughout their lives. The following tips can help Mediators improve their own self-confidence to ensure that they're promoting this trait in their kids as well:

- Write down one strength and how it helped in overcoming a specific challenge. ("My eloquent speaking helped me to nail my most recent job interview.")
- Think of something that causes fear or hesitation regularly – possibly a fear of failure or criticism – and write down three things to do to overcome this fear, such as taking a class on speaking skills to overcome a fear of public speaking.
- Work toward becoming an expert in a specific skill, like mastering the guitar or becoming fluent in a second language – something that really promotes a sense of competence.
- Make a commitment to practice positive self-talk, as nothing brings down confidence as quickly as the negative thoughts that people have about themselves.

Meeting Them Where They Are

Attentive and compassionate, Mediators really do excel at supporting their kids and providing them with copious amounts of affection. When they become too caught up in the big picture, however, these parents may find themselves ignoring the details of their children's experiences. Kids at this stage want to be heard, understood, and have their experiences validated. These types are more than capable of providing the unconditional love and acceptance that their children need and can use these skills to hone in on what their children truly crave to feel understood.

Mediators who are prone to fixating on the big picture can benefit from focusing on what their children are dealing with in the moment. Some ideas for engaging with their kids in the "here and now" can include:

- Start a gratitude practice at bedtime (or whenever works) where both parents and children state three things that they're grateful for that day and one thing that's bothering them.

- Have a parent/child date once every week or two with the intention of spending time listening to each other and not merely entertaining them.
- Listen, make eye contact, and express interest whenever children are speaking, and make sure parents aren't daydreaming or staring at a screen.
- Always acknowledge their frustrations, fears, or disappointments by using phrasing such as, "I really see how frustrated you get when..." or, "I understand your fear of..."

Find Thyself (From Approximately 12 to 18 Years)

Adolescence is the transition from childhood to adulthood where kids focus on developing their own distinct sense of identity. This transitional period centers around the individual's sense of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, adolescents in this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. Educational and future career goals are made and relationships are developed based on how they align with these values and beliefs, making this a pivotal, foundational stage for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Relationships

Promote Positive Values

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. Mediator parents encourage their adolescent children's growth by promoting positive values, such as responsibility, compassion, and honesty, while providing them with freedom to explore these values in their own ways. As difficult as it can be, parents who have been through this process themselves understand the importance of assisting their children in their personal development and do so to the best of their ability.

Regardless of the struggles that everyone may face during this tumultuous time, Mediator parents can remain steadfast in their devotion to their children. Their dedication to the promotion of their

positive values, as well as their compassion toward their children, provides a solid foundation which allows identity-seeking teens to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of support and love.

Authentic and Committed

Adolescence is a tumultuous stage for most teenagers as they attempt to determine who they are and who they want to be. These discoveries are often made through trial and error, meaning many mistakes can be made. As one of the most authentic personality types, Mediators' honesty and unwavering commitment are indispensable during this stage. Honesty is necessary to help teens learn from their mistakes – adolescents who skip class need to know the potential consequences of this behavior before it's too late. Their parents' steadfast commitment can provide adolescents with the confidence to communicate with them even when topics are uncomfortable.

If Mediator parents can maintain their kind understanding, minimal judgment, and authentic communication when their adolescents come to them with something truly serious – getting pregnant, getting suspended or expelled, or milder stuff like a rough breakup – they can establish themselves as a true source of stability and wisdom for life when their kids need it most. As overwhelming and terrifying as some of these situations may seem, Mediators who can tap into their confidence and empathy can confront these situations from a place of wisdom rather than one of panic. They can treat their teens with respect, but they're still the wise, understanding adults in the room.

Unbalanced Adolescent Relationships

Failing to Establish and Enforce Boundaries

The process of personal discovery is a favorite topic for many Mediators who gladly pass their passion for growth and development on to their adolescent children. This is all fine and good – until these parents prioritize the process of self-discovery over establishing or enforcing healthy boundaries for their children. Allowing inappropriate behavior for the sake of "finding oneself" isn't only unwise, it's downright dangerous.

Despite the gains that they've made in both intelligence and communication skills, adolescent brains aren't fully developed. The prefrontal cortex – the area of the brain responsible for complex planning, decision making, and regulating social behaviors – isn't fully operational until individuals reach their mid-twenties. Children at this stage are literally incapable of fully understanding all the potential consequences of their behavior and, as a bonus, suffer from poor social and emotional regulation. Mediator parents who avoid setting and enforcing boundaries because they're afraid of infringing on their children's autonomy can set them up for failure.

Forgoing a curfew for teenagers out of respect for their independence can come with serious risks, as teens without supervision are more likely to engage in dangerous and illegal activities. Underage drinking, illegal drug use, vandalism, and unsafe sex can seem even more exciting. Even the most mature adolescents can make poor choices when tempting situations combine with poor boundaries and no supervision.

Difficulty Detaching

The adolescent stage requires that children become more independent, making critical life choices on their own and relying less on their parents for basic support. Mediator parents can struggle with feelings of rejection if they believe that their children no longer need them or desire their affection. They may also find themselves mourning the end of their children's childhood, remembering those sweet kindergarteners that they walked into class on the first day of school. If they become too absorbed by a sense of loss at this stage, these types can slip into an existential crisis of sorts, pining for days gone by rather than looking forward to the opportunities that lie ahead for both them and their kids.

Additionally, for some Mediators, parenthood is their "purpose" and the most important part of their identity. If they fail to maintain or nurture other parts of their identity throughout their children's younger years, these parents may fervently hold on to their role as primary caregivers. If parenting has prevented them from maintaining friendships, pursuing meaningful hobbies, or engaging in enjoyable work, they may feel lost and lonely as their children inevitably begin to spend more time away from home. They may begin to experience bitterness, a deep sense

of loss, and even a sense of panic about the uncertainty of their own future with this defining role no longer at the center of their lives.

Rebalancing Adolescent Relationships

Creating Responsible Boundaries

Boundaries are necessary for children of all ages to gain skills and confidence in a safe, understanding environment. Mediator parents aren't doing their adolescents any favors by sending them into the world without guidelines or discipline. The dangers of this permissive approach are much more prominent than any potential benefits. While enforcing rules and restricting behaviors goes against Mediators' live-and-let-live nature, it's important that they learn to appreciate and value these skills for the safety and security that they provide.

Adolescents often believe themselves to be indestructible and are unable to fully realize the potential consequences of their actions. Mediator parents are responsible for creating boundaries for their teens, from curfews to consequences for inappropriate behaviors. Kids who are failing one of their classes may need to be restricted from social activities or screen time until their grades improve. Likewise, adolescents who have been spending time with a troublesome peer may need a strictly enforced curfew. Mediators may chafe at these types of restrictions, but they're ultimately providing structure and security that their adolescent children are unable to provide for themselves. The following tips can help Mediator parents have a productive conversation about boundaries with their children:

- Make sure that these conversations take place when everyone involved is amenable. Shouting about boundaries and expectations when individuals are angry is unproductive and often prevents buy-in.
- Use humor when possible.
- Use age-appropriate language to explain how certain boundaries can benefit adolescents both in the present and future.

Promoting Responsible Independence

The adolescent stage requires that kids become increasingly independent from their parents by building their own sense of identity and personal values. This can be especially difficult for Mediators who thrive on being their children's caretakers or identify primarily as parents. Rather than viewing their children's increasing independence as the death knell to their parental role, however, they can focus on viewing this new stage in their kids' lives as both a beautiful and necessary part of their personal evolution.

Parenthood doesn't end – ever. From birth until death, parents retain bonds with their children that are unparalleled in both influence and meaning. Each stage represents a new level of this bond and an opportunity to pass on hard-earned wisdom. Mediators who are struggling to let go of the current manifestation of their role as parents can benefit from pursuing their own personal growth. The following tips can help Mediators step back and focus on finding themselves while also remaining a source of advice and inspiration to their children:

- Embrace a spiritual or meditative practice.
- Take up (or rediscover) an artistic hobby such as writing, painting, photography, or sewing – practice a skill and enjoy the benefits of some creative healing and inspiration.
- Take this opportunity to engage in some self-reflection through journaling or even guided counseling to better understand who they are and who they would like to become.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Mediators have their own unique strengths and weaknesses that they need to leverage to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development that takes place when becoming a parent, and Mediators can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

The advice provided above is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Mediators share. Every child is different, and parents are the best judge of what their children need. The advice above should be used in a way that works best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it's best to consult with a professional pediatrician or pediatric psychologist to come up with a plan that works best for everyone involved.

Final Words

Every relationship comes with its challenges, but as Mediators know, the beauty of fully connecting with another person is among life's greatest gifts. People with this personality type have an abiding hope in the power of love and friendship. This sense of hope helps them keep putting in the effort necessary to build lasting, meaningful relationships.

That said, not even the most optimistic Mediators can "fix" the problems in their relationships by themselves. Romantic partnerships and friendships require both parties to invest their energy and care. At times, people with the Mediator personality type may need to ensure that their generosity and compassion aren't being taken advantage of. But by being honest about their needs and feelings, Mediators can give other people the opportunity to show up for them. Mediators pride themselves on being authentic, and as they gain experience in relationships, they find that being open in their communication is the key to staying true to themselves.

In these pages, we've discussed how Mediators bring their many gifts to their romantic relationships, their friendships, and – if they have children – their role as parents. We've also discussed how Mediators can work with their intrinsic traits to embrace a balanced, sustainable approach to their connections with others. It's our hope that these insights are heartening and empowering and that they help Mediators cultivate beautiful, life-affirming, uplifting relationships that brighten their days and allow them to share the fullness of their love and care with others.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not, dear Mediator – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might be the right next step for you:

- Want more tests and insights to help you better understand and strengthen your relationships? Explore our Relationships Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Mediator Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? The *Mediator Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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